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Virginia Board of Education, Work Session, Wednesday, October 19, 2022

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=b8yPRq2R_jQ
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-23. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:24:51] of the Board of Ed. We are delighted today to have a couple excellent speakers with us. First will be Dr. Mark Schneider, Director of the Institute of Education Sciences from the USDOE. Thank you very much for being with us. Yeah, let me tell you, it's still optional.

[00:25:14] You can run. Yeah, you will be the first to actually run successfully, but you could give it a try. No, no, sorry, we don't do long intro comments. I would also note that Dr. Dr. Davis Vaught is participating remotely with permission, you know, due to medical issues.

[00:25:32] Pam, hope you're doing well. Okay. I think I'll do it from there. Thank you, Pat. Okay. So, thank you for that concise introduction. Oh. Oops. So, I'm, again, March Knight, I'm the Director of the Institute of Education Sciences.

[00:25:49] We have a rather large portfolio, and one of the things that we do, and in fact, one of the largest projects that we run is the National Assessment of Education Progress, called NAEP or the nation's report card and the so I was asked to talk about NAEP and to do I'm calling NAEP 101 to give you some background on NAEP and as you know on Monday the 24th the 2022 results will come out and I'll talk about I can't talk about them in any detail but you'll know on Monday you'll see on

[00:26:27] Monday what they are. So the purpose, I was asked to just give a rundown of the kinds of things that NAEP does and I'm going to focus on Virginia. The other thing, of course, is please ask questions any time you want. I am a native New Yorker. It's really hard to be rude to me. So you could interrupt all you want and I will just think, yeah, of course, way it is. Okay. So what is NAEP? So what is NAEP? So it's the National Assessment of Education Progress. It goes back -- some parts of NAEP go back to the 1970s. Other parts are more recent.

[00:27:07] It's known as the nation's report card. And here are the components of it, the major components. So sometimes you hear people talk about main NAEP, right? So main NAEP is the big assessment, the one that you'll be hearing about on monday uh that's by law the no child left behind act set this up it's every two years except we did years because of the pandemic so it was uh we gave it in 19 2019 and would have been in 2021 and instead we had to delay it for a year because of the the pandemic um this is the big this is the big the big one uh there are several hundred

[00:27:44] thousand students in each of fourth and eighth grade um in we then report by over 5 000 schools in fourth and eighth grade nationally representative samples we give the test we give the test as i noted in person um and this is every every two years fourth and eighth grade reading the math so that's the main nape uh when we report we report the national results but we also report state by state and virginia will be obviously one of the states that we will be reporting on in um on monday um but here's the other thing that we do we give the we do large urban district

[00:28:24] results uh and these are called tudas t-u-d-a the trial urban district assessments i'll show you a map later about uh which which are the large urban districts that are included and not one virginia county not one virginia city is in the tudas and if i were you i would think about that right um and i'll show you the map the north carolina i think has at least two maybe three um districts

[00:28:52] represented in that um it's so right now i think uh probably some of the northern counties would would fit because could be counties uh because in the south county school districts uh i'm not sure richmond is a county system so so right now the there's state i'm sorry there are districts that are trying to get in it's a money thing but um do you have something you know uh i don't remember offhand but you look i mean you can see the list i'll show you the list later on and you could do

[00:29:28] you got to be bigger i mean the northern districts have got to be bigger than the just some of the districts that are in there so yeah so if i may yeah just a follow-up question And thank you, Mr. Rotherham, for breaking the wall. The fourth wall. Starting. So I do think, I think at least a couple of our Northern Virginia Dirks, and it may be Virginia, which is also a large district, might qualify size-wise.

[00:29:50] But what's the process? I mean, do they have to opt in? Do they have to pay a fee? You have to apply, and then we have to find the resources to make it happen. Do we, the state, pay the fee? No, no. Does the locality pays the fee? So the problem is that we're running out of money for Tuda. So we need more money from the Congress to expand the TUDA assessment, because there are many more urban districts, large urban districts that should be included.

[00:30:15] And I'll show you, well, maybe I should just show you the map now. - But so somebody in your agency makes the decision on who to include in TUDA. - Well, there's a map, I don't know if you could see it, but you could see, so the Northwest is empty, the West, which is pretty much the Northern part, including Wyoming are small, so they don't have districts that compare that could work.

[00:30:42] But you can just see some of these districts in North Carolina, there are several, right? Guilford County, Guilford County's there, Jefferson County, Kentucky, Shelby County, Charlotte, you gotta be, your Northern districts have to be bigger than Charlotte, right?

[00:30:59] So I don't think it's, I think it's a money question and I think it's a political question, quite frankly. but you should take that up, right? Because I know there are many other districts that wanna get in on it, and we just don't have the resources to do it.

[00:31:16] - I'd like to know why, what kind of politics play into that? You said it's a politics question? - No, it's a money question. - Okay. - Right. So there are other districts that want to be in it, and we just can't expand more, right?

[00:31:33] Given our resources, okay? Again, we can follow up on this later, okay? Okay, so the urban districts and that we work closely with the Council of the Great City Schools.

[00:31:49] You must know those folks, Ray Hart, right? And the first step would seem to be to talk to Ray and his crew at the Council of the Great City Schools and teach more about the actual process.

[00:32:04] Okay, so again, reading and math fourth and eighth grade every two years, and then we do reading and math at the 12th grade, and that's only national. We don't do state reports for reading and math at the 12th grade, and that's only every four years.

[00:32:21] That's in legislation, and again, from my perspective, that's not a good end, right? I think we need state by state. 12th grade is the capstone, obviously, the K-12 system. We should have reading math stable results.

[00:32:41] Some people argue that the 12th grade is too late. What you really want is the 11th grade, you know, but I mean, this is a report card. It's not a, you know, it's not a diagnostic test. It's a report card. And the 12th grade results, I'll talk about them in a minute, but only briefly.

[00:32:59] They're pretty scary. They're actually pretty scary when we get to STEM subjects, for example. And again, only at the national level. But for me, we need more information, and I personally prefer a state-by-state.

[00:33:16] That would require more money, again, more money, but I think it's something that we actually should be doing. Okay, we also test other subjects on only national, and sometimes grade four, sometimes grade eight, sometimes grade 12.

[00:33:34] It often depends on the schedule that the National Assessment Governing Board sets and in particular needs. Science is done on a semi-regular basis. And that's one of the scariest assessments that we have because we care so much about STEM and the numbers of the percentage of students, especially black and Hispanic students that are below basic in NAEP are the thirds of black students at 12th grade are below basic in science.

[00:34:04] And over half of Hispanic students are below basic in science. I mean, this is a disaster. At the same time, we keep talking about the need for STEM and the need for diverse and large STEM workforce. And we're talking about large populations, black and Hispanic students that are more than half and blacks more than two thirds are below basic, which means they can't hardly do anything with regard to science.

[00:34:28] So where we're gonna get the diverse STEM workforce, this to me is a serious challenge. just quickly i mean i think we these terms get thrown around basic below basic proficient just like in layman's

terms for people watching and for us like yeah just like what what put in like you know like again i guess like you have layman terms like what is that like when you're talking about you say they actually can't do a lot like what does that yeah pretty much if you're below basic you can hardly do anything in in the field right basic is is exactly that just basic you could just do basic arithmetic operations geometry things like that depending on the grade

[00:35:06] there's proficient and then there's advanced um so the levels these levels are based on mastery and ability to solve problems um you know and and um they're carefully determined by the national assessment governing board um the biggest problem so um so in 2002 under the no child left behind act what happened was that we were we focused two things uh three exactly math and reading and that's when the cycle of testing and math and reading fourth and eighth grade was set up um and we focused on proficient but the real problem the real problem is not and and no child

[00:35:46] left kind act as you may remember said that every student was in the nation was supposed to be proficient by 2014 right that was never going to happen it was it was more than an aspirational goal it was um well let's leave it that way it was an aspirational goal um and of course nobody hardly anybody met. I don't know if anybody met it. But the real problem in the last four years while I've been at IES, I've been trying to, and I think successfully, shift the focus away from proficiency and advanced to below basic, right? So the below basic are, and there's a large range below basic,

[00:36:24] but essentially if you're below basic in reading and below basic in math, below basic in science, there's not a lot you could do what about app basic is that what what about app basic are you are you on track for college and career at the basic level or is the proficient level actually i did a study in using virginia data working with todd on on that um so it's it's it's complicated there's no direct pathway between the levels uh so we don't have grade level proficiency it's one of the things i mean i know that in states proficient usually means grade

[00:36:59] your own grade. Nate doesn't have anything that's like that. So it's just mastery, the level of mastery. So I'm trying to remember, I did the work with Todd a long time ago. But if you're proficient, and certainly if you're advanced, you have a good chance of getting into college and through college, right? It's not 100%. None of these scores are 100%, right? I mean, would you think it's like a red flag? That's what I'm trying to figure out. Below basic is unbelievable red flag, right? And what's happening with below basic is that the percentage of students who

[00:37:34] are below basic is growing. And if we look at, and again, I'll just show you some Virginia data in a minute. If you look at black and Hispanic below basic, black below basic, it is huge numbers. So this is the kind of things when people talk about gaps, that's why, I mean, so sometimes we just talk about gaps in terms of score, but the biggest, the biggest issue is the percentage of students that are below basic by race. And again, in a minute, I'll just show you some of the numbers. Okay. So we do writing tests, which is very difficult to do

[00:38:09] because you want people to really do writing. And I'm working on a project to do much more artificial intelligence-assisted writing and grading. And then we do social studies, social sciences every once in a while geography history and civics and andy you must have something to say about civics i hear it's a bit of a problem it's a bit of a problem um sciences and all these things are a bit of a problem uh because there's such contention about the about what goes into

[00:38:44] these tests right um they're all driven by a framework and the discussion of the framework can't be extremely extremely contentious um we did a reading we did a reading uh frank new reading framework uh two years ago um and that was bad enough but um but science and especially civics um is is i will be out of office by the time because those are those are those are going to be those are going to be scary what grade levels are these science assessment and

[00:39:19] what grade levels are they oh i'm sorry um so there's no i mean it's either fourth eighth or twelfth depending on the year and the subject area right so we don't science and science and writing writing we did fourth eighth and twelfth we did the writing assessment in 2011 um and then we did one in 2017 which we weren't not able to release for for technical reasons sorry for technical reasons. The next writing assessment would be in 2030. Science we did in 2019,

[00:39:54] but only at the national level. And we did fourth, eighth, and twelfth grade national. So in terms of international assessments, like the PISA program for international students, you know, the U.S. is almost stuck at average or below average for science and math, either near there and literacy too you might as well get that one in there yes so how does this i mean is there any kind of how can you can you draw any kind of conclusion correlation anything between yeah so we're very active in in oecd right the organization that runs pisa um and we do linking

[00:40:33] studies and we do you know matching studies uh it is true right the u.s uh so as long as you're talking about PISA, just quickly, the U.S. is always in the middle of the pack, right? We lag most of our most important competitors, right? Who, especially Asian countries, are usually at the very top and we're always in the middle. And for a long time, the argument was that, well, that's okay. It was never really okay. But because our best students were world-class.

[00:41:06] And not just that, I mean. That is not true. So we have a smaller proportion of our students in the top level you know pisa grade level five um and it's less than other countries and it's been declining yeah new and gentlemen at um capital and for their ai uh they they say that their recruitment they're 80 more than 80 of them are from outside the country they just he talked about that there's no pipeline of stem in this country

[00:41:41] so he it's a problem it's a problem yeah i mean it's a serious problem and and again i mean so we um well i'm not going to get into our immigration policy but obviously we lived on it you know importing talent for a very long time and and of course that's a contentious issue for different reasons um but we but we we do we do need to seriously think about our stem pipeline i mean Again, we want a diverse, strong, big pipeline and with 69% of Black students below basic

[00:42:16] and 56% of Hispanic students below basic in science with roughly the same numbers in math. And again, this is national. We'll take a look at the Virginia numbers in a second. Okay. The other -- the last thing I want to talk about is something that came out in September.

[00:42:37] We run something called Long-Term Trends, and that's only a national assessment, goes back to the 1970s. We do math and reading, and that, so NAEP, Maine NAEP is grade-based, Long-Term Trends is age-based, so it's 9, 13, and, I'm sorry, it's supposed to be 17 or not 15-year-old students and not based on grade levels.

[00:43:04] so i'll show you some results in a minute about the about the nine-year-old uh long-term trends that we just released in september and and that was we we literally closed the assessment in 2020 on

march the 10th and you know what happened on march the 15th and thereabouts we got out of the field literally a week before the the world closed down and then we went back into the field in January of '22. So we did an assessment. I mean, I looked around this room, but I think pretty much we're all acting as though the pandemic is over for now. Schools are open, thank God.

[00:43:45] And so we went back in the field in '22. So we have a nationally representative sample of nine-year-olds, literally the week before the pandemic stuck. And then we did it again in january through march um so that's a nationally representative sample of nine-year-olds we're doing 15-year-olds also um and um and i'll show you a couple of results in a minute but not not not pretty yes ma'am this is incredibly helpful thank you the uh just so i understand the process on so the main nape the scores that are coming out next week are based on a separate field

[00:44:25] Experience from the long-term trends name. It's a so again the nine-year-old so it's age-based, right? It's not it's not it's not it's not just a different interpretation. No, no, no, no, totally different Taste administration exactly and what is the timing so that you just described to us the long-term trends timing of the administration?

[00:44:44] What's the timing of main nape so so main nape was pretty much the same time as the um as the ltt the long-term trends for nine-year-olds we went into the field in january came out at the end of march of 20 of this year 22 and that's the the normal window for long-term trend i'm sorry for main nape is january to the end of march and we try to keep it at the same time um all you know every time we do the assessment because one of the most important things about nape is that it's is it can measure trends so but i'm confused because we i think of uh the nape numbers

[00:45:21] as being odd number years and you're administering it in even years we were supposed to do it in 21 and we couldn't do it in 21 because of the pandemic and we got uh we had to go to congress and they gave us a waiver to do it in thank you thank you so your january 22 is is is the delay January 21 and and there's I mean there's some risks associated with moving into even years so this is going to come out uh like two weeks before the midterms and then in two years will come out two weeks before the presidential elections um and um and you know so that there's a political risk

[00:45:59] in in it but we yeah we just couldn't do anything else um we could theoretically we're not going to do one year the things don't move fast enough for one year anyway but it's an answer okay um so this is so this how how are nape results reported so they're reported as scale scores which um you know so like you might see a score 250 300 it's on a scale of up to 500 um the and and there have been arguments about the scale scores and should you know should they be the only thing reported um

[00:46:36] but the the most interesting things the things that that real people could get their heads around most easily are the achievement levels right so they are based on cut scores on the nape score on the nape scale so there's really three achievement levels basic proficient and advanced but the fourth category below basic right so those are the those are the four um categories right so there's below basic and and three official cut points basic proficient and advanced

[00:47:12] these are set by nagby and and um you know there's all kinds of psychometric policies that go on um but they're important and and obviously the proficient cut point is the used to be the one that everybody was focused on but increasingly i believe we should be focused on the below basic because again citizens that can't do that don't even reach neat basic are going to have they're going to struggle and

we are so in part for the last 20 years we've talked about proficient um and only recently talked about below basic but we don't know a lot about what's going on

[00:47:48] below basic it's just like one clump and um and we don't have enough questions about what people below basic could do but we're working on on trying to fix that out uh fix that okay so the other thing that's important are um results are repeat are reported by race ethnicity free and reduced price lunch status, disability, English language learner status. It's reported by region.

[00:48:14] Again, the main NAEP is reported by state and TUDA. And this allows you to start looking at achievement gaps between the different groups. And the last point is that trend analysis going back to the 1990s and main NAEP and to the 1970s for long-term trend are are possible and and preserving trend is one of the most important things that uh that NAEP cares about and it's an interesting discussion because it to maintain trends you have to keep things pretty much as they are but then

[00:48:52] things fall out of you know they start lagging behind reality the world changes so we're measuring things that like nobody cares about anymore and this is one of the biggest problems with long-term trends so updating the updating the frameworks is a is is actually a very difficult task because you want to update the the the framework to reflect modern education in modern society but if you if you change it too much then you can't report trends in okay so um so most useful for states is the is the is the main state results right and and this is where nape the one

[00:49:31] of the most important parts of NAEP exists, and I assume there'll be some questions about truth. And NAEP, so the important part about NAEP is that it's a common yardstick, right? It's a common yardstick that allows states to compare themselves to one another and to the nation as a whole. So this is really important. You know, states set their own proficiency standards and even when they join common balance or whatever.

[00:50:02] So that reduces the amount of freedom that states have to set their test and their cut points. But the fact of the matter is that NAEP is a common yardstick that states can compare themselves to. So states can compare themselves to other states, right?

[00:50:20] I'm sure that you compare yourself to North Carolina. I'm a target, by the way. so but my daughter did go to uva so i yeah but my other daughter was also tarheel so um so this is the part the common yardstick is is most important so here's an example of and i just did the top um states uh so all the states are lined up in a state comparison chart that looks something like this um you can see that of course all eighth grade math so so every grade and every subjects of a chart like this is you can find this for eighth grade math fourth grade math eighth grade

[00:50:58] uh english and fourth grade english um i just want to call your attention to a couple things so virginia actually um and i don't think surprisingly given its wealth and its its commitment to education um does reasonably well right i'm sure that everybody wants to be the top the doda is the the Department of Defense schools, right?

[00:51:21] So at 287, that puts it about 10th. And you can see at above basic, you go all the way. So six points above the national score, it has 75% of its populations at or above basic, and 38% are at above proficient, OK?

[00:51:41] You can flip it around, 25% are below basic, right? OK, so this is like one of the league tables, or whatever you want to call it, this is one of the ways in which you can compare Virginia to other states. And

again, I didn't show you the bottom, but every state has a line that looks like that, okay?

[00:52:00] And just keep in mind the percent proficient because that's based on NAEP, right? And it's 38%. So you just need to just keep that number in mind if you want to talk about the state level measurement proficient versus this okay then their state their state snapshot reports and it's a useful tool so as a lot of information and there's one for each state for each subject grade combination so this is the eighth grade eighth grade and there's a comparison data it's very sorry it's hard to read

[00:52:40] which is something I always you know anyway you can look at this so you can look here, you can see the percent, the achievement levels, and again, you could just look at where Virginia is. Each state has a chart like this, and then here are the scale scores. You could see over time, Virginia has been above the national average throughout, through the whole time, right? The gap is shrinking a little bit, which you will know in, you know, less than a week what that gap looks like again, but that's an example of the kind of information

[00:53:18] that you'll have on 24, this line. We'll extend it for you. I mean, we'll update this, and you'll just see that that line continues, okay? Here's a, this is the kind of gap analysis that's possible. So this is the table that they report, some interpretation, but I just pulled out some information and presented it in a much bigger table that's easier to read i think so below basic eight percent of whites are below basic 24 percent of

[00:53:51] black students are below basic grade eight math uh hispanic nine percent asian five or two or more races and nationally 20 of the students are below basic so you can see there's a huge race problem right and again you're not alone in this right but this is this is big this is a big difference yes ma'am free and reduced lunch free and reduced lunch um and any you must have some analysts here you could use or you could do yourself the neat data explorer you could pull it out and then this

[00:54:28] is present at proficient above whites 57 blacks not surprisingly the worst number 26 percent of proficient above Hispanic 36 Asian 76 two more races 51 and the national so the race gap the race gap in virginia is very long here's this is one of the this is one of the things that um is really disturbing so this again um this reading um so if you look you can see that the lowest performing

[00:55:05] students are the ones that are experiencing the the most severe drop in scores okay so that's 12 point drop which is huge and neat okay they went down in two years the 10th percentile went down by 12 points the 90th percentile went down by one point which is not statistically significant but the point is that we see this in increasingly we see that the bottom of the distribution is falling further and further and further behind and the top i mean the top's not doing great

[00:55:42] this goes back to your point earlier about compared to pisa for example how our top students are doing not so well they're declining they've declined a little bit or their status status quo but the bottom is falling out the bottom is falling out for our lowest performing students and we this is a serious problem and here this i mentioned long-term trends so this is again national this is nine year old okay and again all you have to do is look at these numbers at the 90th percentile the decline in reading um over two years was um two two points but if the 10th percentile was minus

[00:56:20] ten points this is um for math at the top down three points everybody went down the code is pre and post this is uh 2019 22 um and at the 10th percent how it went down 12 points these are these are drops that we've never seen and this shows up in almost every assessment now that the lowest performing

students are the ones that are sinking the furthest and the fastest and we could measure and if we did this by race if we did this by ethnicity if we did it by supreme school uh

[00:56:58] freedom the biggest declines are in the students that are getting the sort of worst or that needed that need the most including and they're the ones that are falling from the further behind it's a yeah it is a serious problem yes ma'am so this this is obviously post-covid but the prior chart you showed us showed the same trend in a pre-covid data comparison on the name main neighborhood right how long has that trend been going on that the bottom students are getting worse well okay so so i'm going to admit that um we weren't looking at that right we were not looking

[00:57:35] at that until a couple of years ago and and and um and um you know this is um let's say my bad um but except in my office for four and a half years and like from the get-go i said like no this This is what the nation needs to know.

[00:57:52] This is what the nation needs to deal with. And it's the same thing like with below basic, right? I mean, that's what we have to... If we want productive citizens, if we want people to have jobs, if we want people to be productive democratic citizens, they can't be that far behind and falling further behind.

[00:58:12] - The previous slide was Virginia data. This is also Virginia data. - No, this is national. So the long-term trends is only national, right? And we'll know more again. On Monday, you'll be able to extend the information from 19 to 22.

[00:58:28] So, based on everything we know, I can tell you without divulging anything secret, it's going to be nasty. It's going to be nasty. Can you -- I mean, in this a little bit, your next slide, like, you give us -- I know you can't preview the date anymore than what you just did, and I know I haven't seen it, but like, could you just do like an informed person's guide to what to look for on Monday, what Like, if you want to be an intelligent consumer of when this date all drops on Monday, what should you look for?

[00:58:58] What should you look for? So, look, I mean, there, so everybody's telling us the same thing. There are going to be big declines. So here's, but here's an interesting question. So we had a three-year gap between when we did the, you know, NAEP in 19 and 22.

[00:59:17] They're going to be everything, long-term trends, NWEA, everybody's predicting pretty nasty performance. So there's going to be the state-by-state comparisons, right? And I've seen the results. I must admit that the first thing I looked at was what everybody else is going to look at, except for you, because you're going to look at Virginia. But I was looking at, well, California versus Texas and New York versus Florida, right? So, I mean, there's to be the horse race part right the league tables everybody's going to be looking at that um and you

[00:59:54] know the there these these kinds of results could feed into the midterm elections right so this is part of the reason why having the results in odd years was much better than having them in even years but we you know covet came along and screwed up a lot of things so you could so there will be based on everything we know you should expect declines and probably some big ones. So again, since you're the Virginia Board of Education, I assume that you're going to look at the Virginia

[01:00:27] data compared to the nearby states and the states that you compare yourself to. You should look at that. And then when these state by state results come out, you can do it yourself. I mean, we just students as a service but and you know like able to do it on monday the the uh data explorer will be updated you could have any you know any reasonably good analyst to you know pull up whatever you need

done um but um but based on these the numbers we've already seen you should be looking at what's happening at the bottom of the distribution what's happening at um you know

[01:01:04] below basic what's happening to uh with racial and ethnic minorities and then uh and and students especially sorry i need to turn this off i'm sorry i forgot to do that before um so those are the kinds of things that you're going to have to that that you're going to look for there's a lot of data in it right so imagine you know two different tests uh two different grades 50 states district of columbia's in there um so you need you you there there'll be a lot of there'll be a lot of data in there um but they're the pattern you should look for these right how do virginia do compared to North Carolina, compared to whoever else,

[01:01:43] I'm not even sure, again, I just default to North Carolina. But what other states are there? How do you do compared to other states? What's going on at the bottom of your distribution? What's going on with your black students who you obviously have a serious racial gap issue?

[01:01:59] Yes, ma'am. - So I have a basic question about the LT versus the main. What, it's the completely different tests? - It's a different test. - Completely different tests. So the long-term trends, it uses this. - These are all multiple choice. - They're all multiple choice. I'm sorry, LTT is long-term trends is multiple choice.

[01:02:17] The main NAEP has some constructive responses. - And how do we know which schools in Virginia participate in these? Do all schools? - No, no, no, it's just a sample.

[01:02:33] I'm sorry, I'm trying to think if we make the schools that are, have been, so we sampled, right? - I just don't remember my children. - No, no, it's a sample. So I'm not sure if we make the list of schools that participated in the public or not.

[01:02:51] I don't remember, so sorry about that. - But is it announced in the school so the parents would know that the children are doing it or not? - Yeah, yeah, yes, yes. So, I mean, I have not many friends, but I have enough friends who's just say, "Oh, my daughter just came home and she took the test and she took me."

[01:03:08] - Okay. - Right, so if you have children and they didn't come home and say, "I just spent four hours doing this test." That means your school-- - Four hour? - Yeah. - Oof. - And so-- - Actually, I'm sorry, I think it's three hours. - I was looking at your data explorer and you mentioned, I'm looking at 13-year-old math.

[01:03:31] It was long before 2021 that the math trends have been, long-term trends have been going down actually since 2012. Do you know why? - Do I know why? You're the Board of Education. I'm just a layman.

[01:03:48] No, no, I mean, if you look at the trend line for long-term, I'm sorry, for main NAEP, so I was the commissioner. No, I'm just talking about the long-term. No, no, but it's the same answer, by the way. Okay. Okay. I mean, thankfully, the scores of long-term trend and main NAEP track, right?

[01:04:07] Otherwise, there would be a real problem. So when I was the Commission of NCES between 05 and 08 We Released NAEP results and and it was like one of the happiest days of my life Right because scores were going up the cross the board scores were going up in 05 and 07 08 I mean, it was really like only not only good news, but mostly good news But if you look at after about 11 or 12 flat flat flat flat declining, there's been very little growth in

[01:04:43] Very steady decline more than a fast. Yeah. Well depends on the score depend. It depends on the test but the fact the matter is that things are bouncing along in a flat in a very narrow range with with unfortunately secular declines, but not big yet, right, but I mean in long-term trends we saw a nine-point decrease in in long-term trends and Nationwide in I think that was reading and 12 points for math or vice versa We've never, ever seen drops like that, ever.

[01:05:19] So, yeah, I was reading some news reports, and it was mentioned that 2012 is when Common Core was implemented in many parts, and some articles seem to attribute Common Core to the reduction in this decline in these cores.

[01:05:40] What are your thoughts on that? Actually, I don't have any on that. I mean, I can't talk to that point. Can I ask a couple questions? Sure. You mentioned, gee, we ought to be comparing ourselves to other states.

[01:06:00] And I guess I'm not clear of the value of that for us. To me, you know, and I think you published a blog post last month about not letting a good crisis go to waste. And that's really, I think, what the board, what I personally would like to hear is, how do we allow this crisis not to go to waste?

[01:06:23] And I think you've come up with essentially three ideas. One is teaching reading better, now that we know so much more about the science of reading, which the state has adopted now. Could you go over, though, the other two? You talk about scalable interventions that work and data assessment within schools.

[01:06:43] Would you mind? Because, I mean, as you mentioned, I think it's one of the first things. You know, NAEP is sort of the, you know, the report card, the temperature taken. It's not an assessment of an individual student as such, although I know it's a combination. But it doesn't give us actionable data except at the system level.

[01:07:00] So what actions would you take at the system level to begin to reverse the trends? I will also say that, you know, I've looked at a lot of this data. some of our NAEP declines in the last decade plus are, you know, explainable by changes in the demographics of the school divisions, I mean, of the system as a whole. As we have more high-poverty kids, as we have more English learners, there's an anticipated decline in NAEP scores based upon the under-resourcing of, you know, well, the expected performance of certain socioeconomic classes. But that's outside of this question. In terms of where

[01:07:36] we're going as a board yeah what would you do so um so reading is to me is one of the um one of the uh i want to be careful about the wording here so what we what we do with regard to reading instruction is is actually horrendous how about that for not a very uh um what's right modulated word um so uva has some of the best work being done uh with regard to reading instruction so we We have, I mean, IS, my institute, has spent hundreds, hundreds of millions of dollars

[01:08:16] on the science of reading. So we have brain scans, we have cognitive science, we have fMRIs, we have everything that says phonics is the way that you teach reading. In contrast, we've had this movement of whole language instruction.

[01:08:33] It doesn't work. It doesn't work. We know it doesn't work. We know how to teach reading. And the fact of the matter is that many ed schools, many districts still believe in whole language instruction.

[01:08:50] That is, to me, that is unacceptable. That is just unacceptable that we have charlatans teaching reading in ed schools. And then, of course, teachers go and teach what they've learned. So for me, that has to be one of the things that we need to deal with.

[01:09:10] And that's one we've checked off in Virginia and we're making great progress on. but I'm really interested in the next two. - Okay, so scalable interventions is very difficult. So let me just be perfectly honest. Most things in education reform don't work, period.

[01:09:27] They don't work. And so we run the What Works Clearinghouse. We spend about $100 million a year on testing different interventions, right? Our hit rate is about 8% that have evidence that they work.

[01:09:46] And this is where the IES has fallen down, quite frankly, because we were interested in overall, quote, unquote, main effects. That is, you know, what's the average effect? It's the absolute wrong question, right?

[01:10:02] It's just like everything that I was pointing to, like you've got to care about the students in this category, that category, that category, that category. We need to be much, much more careful about identifying the groups of students, groups of students that different interventions work for, because what works for black students in Richmond are not going to work for white students in Blacksburg, right? So we have to be really, really careful about what interventions work for what students. And that is, that is a, that's a serious, serious question. And, you know, if someone comes and says, hey, I have a main

[01:10:38] effect, you know, an average main effect of 0.25, that's great. No, no, no, no, no, no, no. Who does it's work for because nothing works for everybody so we have to be much much more careful about identifying what works for whom under what conditions which is the motto of is that that's our mission um scalable so scalable is so we're investing a lot of money in trying to figure out how to scale things which is really where education sciences because most of this is done by academics they you know i mean for them scalable means they they publish in a better journal right

[01:11:19] no that's not what we need we need things that can go from one school to a hundred schools right that's what we need we need to identify things that are scalable right and that is that's a serious that's a serious challenge because we haven't thought about it enough the other problem quite frankly is that one of the best ways to have something scale is to have it commercialized right but we know the edtech industry in this country is about a 25 billion dollar a year industry and the estimates of how much of that ed tech gets used is scary, right? The majority of

[01:11:58] things of ed tech products don't get used, right? But we have ways of tracking that now. So we're doing a much better job on tracking what things get used. But now we have to track what effect they have. So we as a science agency and commercial developers are often at loggerheads because they say i have this product it works and we say show us the evidence and no no i can't i can't share with you the evidence right because it's commercial it's it's trade secrets

[01:12:33] so so this is a serious problem uh increasingly we will not give money and the federal government in general won't give money to uh research studies that are not open science and open data and i i think that's a national trend I don't know the degree to which you're involved in it, but we should be insisting on open science, right?

[01:12:57] We're doing it. The entire federal government is committed to open science and open data, and you should be. And it's a little tricky, again, because some stuff is actually commercial and has proprietary

value. But if things don't scale, then...

[01:13:15] I mean, one of the things that we spent, and the National Science Foundation put about the same amount of money for a geography intervention that worked, about $11 million went into it, and 2,000 students ever used it.

[01:13:33] For that amount of money, I could have sent all those 2,000 kids to Harvard, right? And they had money left over. So we need to make sure that these things are used, right? So, I'm sorry, Mr. Gecker, what was the third one?

[01:13:50] improve reading available interventions and using increased data assessment at the school level you mentioned something called school pulse ah yes yes yes yes yes yes yes okay thank you um i so so here's the other problem okay so the school pulse i don't know if any of you have seen have seen the school pulse so the problem with a lot of education data is that by the time anybody sees it it's old, right? So we are putting out school finance data from three years ago, which is insane,

[01:14:27] right? And, you know, the urgency, I don't know why, you know, I feel urgency about all this stuff, but like, you know, the bureaucracy is sometimes like, yeah, you know, three years, five years, 10 years, man, you know, we'll get it out when we can get it out. So the thing that we need, the thing that we need, and here's my image, right? So if, if, if, if God forbid, I-95, that bridge on i-95 fell down and we had to rebuild it right we would use modern material sciences to to design that bridge we would have sensors built into the bridge that says the

[01:15:05] concrete is you know the concrete is buckling or the concrete has five more years to go or here's a patch that needs to be replaced the girders the metal would also have built-in sensors right so you would have information all the time about the condition real real world real time information about what's going on on that bridge we don't have anything like that in education nothing interesting so we have so the school pulse is a monthly survey it's a monthly survey

[01:15:37] of a nationally representative sample of schools it's about 45 minutes long it was designed to track school openings and closings. That was the beginning of it. But there's so much more information that we need in real time that the school pulse gives us. We finish the collection and three weeks later, which is like record time, we publish the data for national distribution.

[01:16:07] And it could be about teacher shortages, right? Different kinds of programs that people are using with regard to recovering from covid it's a rotating it we have a core set of questions that are still with regard to mode of instruction and covid and recovery but we insert different modules depending on the need of we we work with the cdc we work with the secretary of education we work with other aid the department of labor and all of the design of this is to get information about a representative sample of schools about what's going on and it's three weeks old not three

[01:16:45] years old so we need more things that look like that we need more things that are embedded in the processes of schools so that we get real time or close to real time feedback okay help me out what would you do with the feedback in other words what can we do interventionally in the school and maybe it's not at the board level now it's at the local level based upon the data that gets produced here. And I certainly don't argue with having more data. That's not the point of this. But at some point, we need to convert. We've known for 20-plus years about achievement gaps.

[01:17:26] The gaps haven't really narrowed. We've known that during the pandemic, scores were going to fall. I mean, a lot of stuff we know and have known for a long time. What would be different in terms of the institutional response or what are we doing wrong? Let me start with this. What have we done wrong? And it's not just Virginia, but everywhere in terms of addressing, and I know everybody likes to refer to it as the black and white achievement gap. I still prefer socioeconomic status because I was talking to one of the USC professors

[01:18:05] the other day about this. All her data is with black and white, race data. I said, why when you know it just correlates to socioeconomics. The answer was we have better data based on race than we do on socioeconomics. But to me, it puts a bad cast on it to continually refer to achievement as specifically race-based as opposed to socioeconomic-based.

[01:18:28] But that's my own pet peeve, and you don't have to adopt that. But for us, if we can't convert the data to policy, the data has no meaning for us. And so where did the board fail 20 years ago? Where did the legislature fail 20 years ago in terms of adjusting achievement gap problems? And what can we do today with either the long-term data or short-term data to address those deficiencies? So I wish I had better news, right? But unfortunately, the cupboard is not

[01:19:02] stocked with interventions that work, right? So the nicest part, quite frankly, about my job running a science agency and statistics agency is that our charge is to document the stuff and i mean and only in the last few years have we started asking the same kind of questions that you're asking like what really works for whom and how do we make that happen so we've built an incredibly complicated education system as one of my friends once said if you were if you were to design a complex system that you know made things almost impossible to happen you would just look around

[01:19:40] and look at 16,000 school districts in 50 states in the District of Columbia, and you would design a system that was as complicated and as cumbersome as that. It's like an archetypical example of a complicated system. So I wish I had a ready-made answer for you.

[01:20:00] But the fact of the matter is that there's not a lot of solutions. We believe in evidence base. We keep trying to expand the evidence base of what works. But, I mean, I go back to the reading example. We know what works with regard to teaching reading, and we can't get it done.

[01:20:19] We're working on that. As Dr. Siebert said, fortunately, that's one we think we have gotten turned around here with the Literacy Act and its requirements. Right. But just think of after you do that one, then you have writing. Oh, no doubt. And that's why I'm asking you, you know, how do we begin to check the box?

[01:20:35] I mean, based what, in 19, if you believe that people who scored or kids who scored below basic really, you know, aren't going to be able to function in society, that's basically 30% of our kids, right? That's scary, yeah. Right? I mean, that's a huge percentage of people that NAEP is saying will not be able to function in society.

[01:20:54] Well, they won't function at a high enough level, at a level that we need or want. There you go. Ms. Holton. So, I am hearing you say that you would focus, if you were us, on your, how do we lift up the bottom? That's the, there are a lot of things we should focus on, but that's one of the most important things we focus on.

[01:21:12] If that's our focus, can you, and I hear you, you're not able to opine more than you have on interventions, but what states with demographics similar to ours in terms of poverty and or race are doing, are superstars on.

[01:21:31] - So Mississippi is the example that everybody uses now. - Well, Mississippi is a superstar because they've moved up. But we're still, Virginia scores are way above Mississippi's, I think. So I'm talking about not in growth now, but in proficiency, so to speak.

[01:21:47] So what states are doing the best job of serving the bottom kids? - So Massachusetts is a clear example. I don't know, have you interacted at all with Massachusetts? - Some, yep. - Yeah, so that's a state that is, and what Massachusetts did, and this goes back to a question which we haven't gotten to, and I don't think we will be able to, this goes back to standards, right?

[01:22:07] So Massachusetts took NAEP standards, which are very rigorous and very, again, maybe even more than aspirational, and they took those as part of their curriculum, right? And David Driscoll was the superintendent and then Mitch Chester unfortunately died, way too young, where the two of them were leaders in pushing Massachusetts forward.

[01:22:35] So, that's a state that's worth talking to, because I think they've accomplished, I mean, they're always at the top of NAEP. I do want to go back to your opening sentence, statement.

[01:22:52] So, I believe that below basic, we've not paid enough attention to below basic, but you know, gifted and talented really matters, right? It really matters. i think in a democratic society we you know we we fight about what that really means and whether or not how much we how many resources should go to the gifted and talented but we can't ignore we can't ignore the very top either right i mean these are citizens that are you know where where where'd google come from where's the next google where's the next amazon where's the next all you

[01:23:26] know i mean we need we we can't we can't neglect the the top of the distribution and it's it's very small. And if you look at PISA data, it's very small. And getting smaller. So we can't – look, I mean, this is a democratic society. We have to be careful about, you know, about things like inequities and et cetera. And to have so many students below basic, for me, is not acceptable.

[01:23:58] But we can't ignore the very top. We need them. I'm glad you brought that up because I was thinking about that too gifted because they're sort of on the one other spectrum they're special needs kids as well on the other spectrum and so are there any tests to to see on a long term or even a short term how has gifted and talented how is that going so um so testing for gifted and talented so the so checker finn you must know do you know checker no so he's done a lot of work on on uh andy knows him

[01:24:34] but i mean he's done a lot of work on on gifted and talented programs and and i would recommend if you wanted to get an expert on that that he'd be someone that you should talk to he's been testing actually testing in terms of testing programs what kind of programs work um you know um so i think you should you you you should talk to him he or he's published two years ago now a year ago he published a book on gifted and talented um and he's done he he was at the fordham Foundation. He was the CEO of the Fordham Foundation. He's now emeritus. He was on the

[01:25:10] State Board of Education in Maryland. So in terms of testing, though, on a national level, nothing exists right now to get the pulse for where advanced. Look at, and that's one point that I was getting ready to make is while we did see declines, obviously, that are very shocking in our below BASIC I

think to me because yeah I I had a focus when I was in the classroom as the coordinator of our gifted programs in a Virginia School

[01:25:45] Division and we that that data that you showed about the decline in the number of advanced testers just is concerning in a lot of ways I mean if you're talking about the lack of number of the number of of students that are you know coming into or being successful in the stem areas um i think it's about bringing everyone up um and so you know i think that that data is just this significant is that truly gifted and talented though i mean gifted

[01:26:20] and talented like fourth grade level they can probably do eighth grade material and if you're giving them the same test they'll probably show up there but i don't know if that's a true test of gifted gifted and talented well i mean look we don't do we don't do state tests we do the national test we have the high we have the the uh you know the the advanced right um so we do pick up the students who are you know at that level so i i one other thing that i think is is really important and again i'm not sure uh what the what what it's like here in in virginia but i can tell you nationwide um the focus has been on reading and math and our science scores have been again using

[01:26:59] the national assessment, our science performance has been abysmal. So we're about to cancel an XPRIZE competition, like an XPRIZE competition, for middle school science interventions that could prove they work. And we thought about whether or not we could actually do this, because the number of interventions in the field of science in middle school is almost an empty set.

[01:27:30] So we put out a million-dollar prize, and we asked people that had interventions to show up. And we were going to run this prize competition. And, you know, at the end of a year, based on actual scores on NWEA, that we were going to award a million-dollar prize, and nobody showed up.

[01:27:55] So I think in part what's happened is that the focus on reading and math has made us forget about science. and our need for STEM is just catching up, right, but we, I mean, science, look, I'm glad you're taking care of reading, but we need to think about science also. So the biggest problem with science is, I'm sorry, many big problems with science, but one of the biggest problems with science is that

[01:28:24] we teach it in a way that turns kids off, right? I mean, kids are born experimentalists, right, and then we kill it. So we need to figure out better how to teach science.

[01:28:44] - President Gecker? May I ask a question, sir? - Certainly. - Dr. Schneider, I don't know if you have this information, but I'm curious about the number of students, high school seniors specifically with the proficient and advanced scores.

[01:29:04] How many of them are in programs such as IB or dual enrollment and things of that nature, Would you have that information? - No, I don't think so, no.

[01:29:20] - Thank you. - But this is where state systems matter, 'cause you do have that information, or you should have that information, right? - And ACT, I think, has some decent data on that. Is that right, Dr. Bala? - It is. - That they can tell us something about student experiences.

[01:29:38] That was not my question, but-- - Yeah, no, that's correct. And at the beginning of the NAEP, not the LTT, but the main NAEP, there is a questionnaire, And states have an opportunity to customize that a little bit. In other words, they can say, we're not gonna answer this, have students answer this section, or we will have students answer this section.

[01:29:56] And so that information is compiled to show trends, but not to say, out of the sample in Virginia, this many students were in IB, this many students took AP courses. That information is not in there, nor is it available.

[01:30:11] And I think it would be somewhat problematic if it was, because it's a sample. and we're sampling a group of students to take a test, not to necessarily see who's in AP courses.

[01:30:26] - Andy, let's see your question. - Sure, yeah, I just think those ACT benchmarks and so forth are pretty good. Dr. Schneider, thanks for being here. There's a couple of things. One, just so I wouldn't sleep on Mississippi. I mean, they're not that far behind us and they're coming up fast and they've done a lot of stuff, particularly with reading and so forth, and they just sort of quietly did it, not so quiet anymore no well yeah now everyone's like noticing and they're the they're the new finland but like they um uh uh you know they've they've it's a it was a sustained effort for about a decade to get serious on this and it's it's pain it's paying some results so i think they're

[01:31:04] not as far behind us as we might like as we might like to think only not that many points um i think six if i'm right but i'm not i'm that's something in that ballpark um uh second like i get i do get troubled i mean this the nape is a sample and so we say well we've got more poor kids that's why scores are going down it's sampling what's happening for those kids and so i mean i think everybody here obviously agrees like demographics are not destiny but this is not telling us that like the state's getting more poor kids for this it's telling us that like those students the sample

[01:31:38] of them that we test that scores are declining and i just think like like if if if taking dr schneider's point that if you're below basic it's a problem like 21 of low-income kids so one in five low-income kids and that's according to your free interest price lunch are below basic and that and and by the way that's not like the way free interest price lunch works this is not like the poorest of the poor that's you know that's families we would we would certainly regard as working class like i mean that's like catastrophic right and this is on the old data which based on what you're saying we should brace for for monday but even the old data one one if i that's catastrophic

[01:32:14] i just don't think we can say well these are just demographic trends and so forth like we've got to figure out a way and there are states and i was surprised this first two questions you didn't talk about like florida the question earlier one of my colleagues asked like states like florida seems like they bucked the trend uh you know their gains for hispanic kids for instance were really noteworthy arizona is doing some stuff like it seems like there are states and i don't think you can draw a causal and be like well is this policy or that policy but there are like things that are happening it's not all sort of just moving in uniform there's stuff that's happening is that right yeah yeah yeah so i mean so the advantage of having the large data so by the way so again you

[01:32:52] must have analysts somewhere that could get the restrict access to the restricted use data for for nape and and actually did much deeper than what we're talking about or what's available on the national data the nape data explorer i don't know that that we've analyzed the data i just know what I've made decisions about as chief that go out to our schools to be answered.

[01:33:16] - Right, but you could-- - And I've had the opportunity. - But this is a very large data set of which we release only this much. - Right. - Right, and we do, I mean, the IS has one of the most liberal policies in terms of making data available through restricted use licenses.

[01:33:34] And that to me is, you know, and it's not that difficult to get license and to use the data so i would you know and and you have some very good universities here if you want to hire someone from a university or someone on staff it's worth it's it's actually worth getting someone a restricted use status license that could look at these that could answer a lot more of these questions and oh go ahead no go ahead please go ahead i'll i'll just wrap it up when you go over here all day i'll be the closer um my other question okay so i was surprised one of the things i heard the most about in the report that came out earlier this year the

[01:34:12] report on student achievement of virginia that came out sometime in the spring april or may i can't recall was a chart in the back that showed what's happened with cut scores and where virginia's cut scores are relative to nape and other states like there's enormous amount of disagreement about that ranging from this is a huge deal to this is nothing to see here please move along like how should we think about that how do cut scores matter i mean that's going to be something that's going to be before this board is thinking about that how should how should we be thinking about that in general you're an expert how should we be thinking about that in the context of like what nape is telling us and presumably will tell us more next week right so nape so look so nape is the

[01:34:48] is a yardstick right so um so i know what was the term the truth gap so yeah the what honesty gap so look i mean yeah so i've written a couple blogs on this and and i use arne duncan so i'm bulletproof on this one um and it's just like the the education system runs on lies right in and you you know so what what do i mean by that i mean states so you know so it's not as bad as it used to be because of things like smarter balance and and the other one um but states were lying like

[01:35:23] crazy about about how many students are proficient so in in using yours your standards right 65 or proficient or above right something like that well nape has you down at like 48 which is you know i I mean, that's pretty good, but it's not 65%.

[01:35:41] And if you look, I know that your scores have been declining and you should be concerned about that. But if you look at the performance, I'm sorry, Virginia was like 10th on that list, the first table I showed you. So your students are, on average, doing pretty good.

[01:35:59] But your SOL, your standards, your cut scores are way too, I mean, we're talking about the same chart. So it's not like the performance of your students is bad. not as good as you want is that the way in which you're setting your cut score for proficient is so far below where you it should be that when you tell me that 68 of your students are proficient and i'm using a national benchmark and it says 48 that's a that's a big disconnect it's not like in detroit the one of the first things about the big lie detroit was reporting something like

[01:36:35] 60 percent of their students were uh were proficient or above and on a three percent more so we you know so so that you're not i mean people lie all the time about their about proficiency but but i i think looking at where you are in that chart in terms of the very last date or the next to last day with regard to the cut points compared to your performance i mean you're you're it's not like you're going out of your way to hide things because you you're not as good as you want to be but you're damn good but your sol and your cut scores are just just not

[01:37:14] reflecting the reality right they're just too low so what's this chart here with i was expecting to see an honesty gap here this one of your charts as virginia above above the nape scores do you know what that is eighth grade math yeah yeah that one because i i thought that

[01:37:43] so here the line for virginia this is above the i'm sorry so so there we i mean if you look here there's 38 in 2019 36 uh were above proficient 12 were um were uh more than uh were advanced so that's 48 right and i think on your on your own assessment 60 something percent are proficient

[01:38:15] and you look at the graph below that this one yeah so that's just those are scale scores that's virginia and the nape right yeah so the the orange line is virginia and the darker line is the nation okay so virginia there the scores are higher yeah yes yes virginia's has scores are higher than the nation higher than the nation yeah one or two exceptions right

[01:38:51] director schneider we um we are so appreciative for you being generous with your time um with your answers etc and uh you know your your wisdom is incredible and at the outset it was in writing but um failed or neglected to uh just just first of all lend our thanks um at the outset uh thank you thank you thank you and also um you know your wisdom is really comprised of four and a half years in the Senate confirmed, four-and-a-half of six years in the Senate confirmed position, work with AIR, work with NCES, and a whole career thinking about things like cut scores,

[01:39:30] accreditation, assessments, et cetera. So I think oftentimes in -- or we're used to in education thinking about the Matthew effect, right, whether we're talking about socioeconomics or what have you. the rich get rich, the poor get poor, and we're struck with this new concept that it's not the Matthew effect because the rich are getting poor and the poor are getting way poor. And so I guess that said, as an entity that is responsible for contemplating and striking some really important education policy, what are maybe three pieces of advice that

[01:40:09] you would give us? You know, you talked about how we should embrace the data on Monday, as we go forward with our talks about accreditation, assessment, and standards, what are three pieces of advice that you would give? And again, we just thank you for your time and wisdom today and look forward to what you'll leave us with.

[01:40:26] I thought I already did that. I already gave you three. Okay. We can leave it there. Can we ask one different question in closing? I mean, because you are, like, so smart on this and you're trained to ask good questions in your career. Like, I'm just curious, you're a four group of policymakers were wrestling with a complicated set of issues on how to improve accountability and so forth in the state like what should we have asked you that we didn't or what are you surprised we didn't what are we surprised that we didn't ask you when you were coming down here you were thinking you were assuming we would we would ask well no look i mean i think we covered the so i struggle with

[01:41:03] these things all the time right i'm and i run you know i mean it's a it's a very small science agency by nsf and nih standards so i'm how do we make things happen how do a we make things happen faster right i mean i think that's critically important i i i feel some degree of urgency so how do we make things faster but not faster for the sake of faster so how do we discover better what works for whom under what conditions so we've been doing a lot of replication work we've been pushing on replication um so one of my jokes is that the education the field of education doesn't

[01:41:39] doesn't have a replication crisis like psychology has, like almost everybody else has. And the reason is because we don't replicate anything. So we have to replicate more things. I think -- I want to be very careful. I was an academic almost my entire life. I want to be very careful about what I say about academics. But your interest in academia don't necessarily align.

[01:42:03] And we've been trying really hard to change the incentive structure. And when we give out money, we give out over $100 million a year in research money, we want to make sure that publishing in some obscure journal is not the goal, but changing facts on the ground.

[01:42:22] And I understand the problem about the school pulse and whether or not this actually leads to policy changes, but we really do have to get better. Again, we would not build a bridge without sensors in it? Why would we build schools without real-time sensors built into it?

[01:42:43] Thank you. All right, Dr. Hovannitz, I was chastised before for not doing a larger and less concise introduction, so I've been handed your entire bio, which I'm delighted to read. All right, Christy Hovannitz is a Senior Policy Fellow for Excel in Ed, focusing on school accountability processes. You served as assistant commissioner at the Minnesota Department of Education and assistant deputy commissioner at the Florida Department of Ed. You've worked on education

[01:43:19] policy for the state of Florida since 1999, serving as director of evaluation and reporting, director of reading first, and a policy analyst for Governor Bush. You graduated summa cum laude from State University with a bachelor degree of science in education, with a minor in math, and you are a certified teacher in the state of Minnesota.

[01:43:42] You have your Master's of Public Administration at the University of Minnesota and a Doctor of Philosophy in Public Administration and Policy at Florida State University. I hope I am not criticized for being too concise with that one. We are very happy that you're with us.

[01:43:58] Accreditation and accountability are things this board will be discussing very soon. It's obviously a hot topic in the education universe and we look forward to your comments. Thank you for making the trip to see us. thank you very much and um looking at the presentation that was loaded it's a previous presentation that i provided to the department and not the current presentation that we're going to walk through today um so i want to be sure that we're all on the same page before i get

[01:44:26] started literally literally yes we have that in the second we we are back live uh thanks for uh

[01:57:27] the patience during the delay we've already done the incredibly long intro so you're on thank you for being here my pleasure so accountability and what we're going to talk about today in and of itself doesn't produce better student outcomes it's what we do what we inspire from those data and policies that we create that are actually going to move us forward so this isn't a conversation to solve all the problems of virginia this isn't a conversation of you know this is what works and this is how it has to be done it's not causation but you have to start with a really good foundation

[01:58:06] so think about what is it what kind of actions are you wanting to inspire from the data and information you get we had a great presentation from dr snyder so we're not going to have to talk real extensively about the difference between standards assessments reporting and accountability but when i talk about them standards all we're talking about is what students should be able to know and do at each grade in virginia we have the cells assessment is just simply a tool that's used to measure whether or not students have met state standards we're going to be talking mainly today about the state assessment which is an assessment of learning versus all the locally administered

[01:58:42] assessments which are assessments for learning so we're really focusing on those outcome assessments reporting is just simply sharing those results you just report those pieces of information out you make them transparent and then accountability is the rating system that you create in order to

determine what supports and interventions should be administered in the schools that are struggling just a quick overview of what it looks like specifically for virginia accountability you have two systems here you have your state accreditation system and then you have a

[01:59:15] federal system which is your essa or every student succeeds act consolidated plan that focuses more and exclusively on student outcomes and has some rigorous expectations to it most states have a single system of accountability or systems that are very very closely aligned so that they are compatible with each other these systems measure things the same things in very different ways we talk about the sol's state assessment these assessments are not comparable to data in any

[01:59:53] other states they're created just for your state standards you have your four achievement levels of below basic basic proficient and advanced and they're administered annually in grades three through 8 and in high school. We don't have data for 2020 because of COVID. In 2021, the participation rates were very low, so we don't have information that we know is extremely reliable for all of the schools. All of the data you're going to be seeing today is mainly from 2019, pre-pandemic, to demonstrate what the impact has been and simply because the comparisons there aren't for federal

[02:00:27] purposes. You're required to participate in NAEP. We just heard that great presentation from Dr. NITR. NAEP is the only tool that comparatively measures student learning outcomes that are apples to apples across states. There is no other measure that you can look at for student outcomes that's comparable across states. Even ACT, because it's not administered universally, isn't comparable across states. Graduation rates, because the different requirements aren't necessarily comparable across states. So this literally is the only measure that we have that's comparable

[02:01:04] student performance state to state. This was one of the ending questions that you talked about in the last presentation is what it looks like for performance in grades four and eight reading and math on NAEP compared to the SOLs. What you see on that top line is, as Mark was saying, that 33 to 48 percent of students were proficient or advanced on the NAEP assessment in 2019 compared that to solve results more than three-fourths of students demonstrated proficiency

[02:01:42] on your state assessments the reason we bring this up and we talk about this is he cited arne duncan whose education is built on lies but when you cite three-fourths of your students are already proficient or advanced and ready to do grade level or college level work, may that be, there's not a sense of urgency to act. You're not really inspiring anything to happen when you're saying that all of your students are faring okay. And you're right, Virginia does have top rankings. You have top 10 rankings in reading performance, but you're seeing declines in

[02:02:21] performance over the last few years. On Monday, you're going to get results for 2022. I'm guessing these declines in Virginia are going to continue on a downward trend. When you're looking at that scale score for fourth grade reading, it changed five points. It went down five points. In the academic and research world, five points is equal to about a half a grade level. So what we're saying is students in Virginia in 2019 are a half a grade level behind where their peers were in 2013. You're also seeing declines in basic performance and proficient performance. So not

[02:02:59] only are kids dropping from advanced and proficient down to basic, kids are slipping from the basic and above into that below basic or that red flag area Dr. Schneider was talking about. We see this trend in reading for both fourth and eighth grade. If this continues, Virginia's top rankings are going to be in jeopardy. You also have top 10 rankings in fourth and eighth grade reading and math. These trends

aren't as dire as reading. I think on Monday, you're going to see that trend probably shift. We know from the long-term trend data that math was impacted more than reading was.

[02:03:36] I think we're going to see more shifts in a downward trend. Again, you're losing ground, not just on your scale scores, but also the percent of students that are proficient at each these levels we also talked about virginia florida and mississippi comparisons and you're right these states aren't comparable um florida virginia florida virginia mississippi really aren't comparable states um virginia has far fewer students eligible for free and reduced price lunch

[02:04:13] florida has 11 percentage points more mississippi has 30 percentage points more students eligible for free and reduced price lunch. Mississippi has more than twice as many black students. Florida has more than twice as many Hispanic students. Virginia also spends more money on education than either Mississippi or Florida. The reason I bring these two states up is I cut my teeth in education policy in Florida. Worked there for Governor Bush during both of his administrations, implemented their school accountability plan, and ran their system for eight years. For the last 10 years, I've not

[02:04:48] only worked in Florida, continuing to maintain that system, but Governor Bryant called us and me to testify to their legislature to talk about what can Mississippi do that Florida did in order to improve their student outcomes. So for the last decade, I've been working in Mississippi to build their accountability system and do some other policy initiatives there. That's why I'm talking about these two states and what we've done in order to improve student outcomes. Sly gets a It's a little bit small, but the basic premise here is that Florida and Mississippi, Black,

[02:05:24] Hispanic, and economically disadvantaged kids read better than their Florida peers in fourth and eighth grade. Virginia might have a top ranking for all students, but because of the way the demographics break out, if you look at individual student groups, Florida outranks every single student group, white, Black, Hispanic, and for a reduced price lunch, and how well they're performing on the national assessment in fourth and eighth grade reading. So Florida outperforms all of their Virginia counterparts across the board. Mississippi is a little bit different story. Mississippi

[02:06:04] outperforms on black, Hispanic, and free and reduced price lunch students, but they don't outperform overall. And the reason why, as we talked about, is demographics are very different in Mississippi than they are in Virginia. But if you're a black student, you're better off getting your education in Florida or Mississippi right now than you are in the state of Virginia.

[02:06:29] So when you look at the data broken out by student group, there is an equity issue here. Florida and Mississippi have established and maintained very rigorous expectations for their students and for their schools and educators and how that plays out in the system.

[02:06:50] May I interrupt? Do you have a comparable chart to that on math and is the implication the same or you're going to get to it? the suspense is killing you isn't it yes that's great that's very useful information thank you um broke it down even further just because i like to look at things not just by race or by economic disadvantage but let's look at it both so the first edge is students who are economically disadvantaged just all students and you can see that 20 of economically disadvantaged students

[02:07:22] in virginia are proficient or advanced readers that's worse than the national comparison or florida or mississippi when you look at black economically disadvantaged students they're doing a little bit better than the nation but again worse than mississippi and florida same thing with hispanic students and

white students so looking at this cross-section of data across tab you're looking at performance in a very different way than just your overall state level ranking,

[02:08:02] which are definitely influenced by demographics. This is looking at economically advantaged students, so students who do not qualify for free and reduced price lunch. If you do not qualify for free and reduced price lunch, you're still better off in Florida or Mississippi in receiving your education for black students, Hispanic students, white students, and Asian students. You'll see black and Hispanic students aren't even represented in Mississippi because they don't have a large enough sample of non-economically disadvantaged black and Hispanic students. So no, Mississippi

[02:08:40] and Florida are not comparable demographically to Virginia, but they are definitely outperforming them on all of the measures of NAEP. Here, the math chart. Fourth grade math looks a lot like reading does. Eighth grade math is where you're still holding some of your ground. Dr. Schneider was nice to pick eighth grade math as all of your examples and show them there. Again, though, as your fourth graders continue to move up, they will be in eighth grade in the next administration of NAEP. Not for Monday, but the next administration, those students are going to show up in eighth

[02:09:15] grade, and you'll start seeing some of those trends as well. I don't want to paint a terribly dire picture, but I also wanted to say, you know, if you don't believe in NAEP, even looking at your SOL data, you're seeing those changes as well. And I think the big thing to notice too is your advanced students are declining, and they're not just dropping to proficient because some of your proficient students are declining and dropping into basic. So it's a shift not just down a level, but some of those that are in the proficient level are shifting down as well into that basic

[02:09:48] and below basic level. Math, again, not as dire as reading yet, but you'll see those advanced kids are pushing down. But as those advanced kids are pushing down, the proficient isn't raising by that much. So they're not just going to proficient, there's kids dropping out of proficient as well.

[02:10:09] So there is a shift in a downward trend across the board, whether you're looking at state or federal data and using all pre-pandemic data. So this isn't influenced yet by what we've seen over the last three years. It's good that we don't have the 2022 data because that's going to be an interesting story. That's going to have other contextualization to it.

[02:10:33] But just remember that this was occurring prior to the pandemic. So it's more of a systematic thing than just a blip of a pandemic that's caused these declines. So what do you do about it? Both Florida and Mississippi really started with the foundation of making sure that they had strong accountability systems.

[02:10:54] And why would we bother with accountability? Well, you know, it's really a relatively new concept. We never used to hold schools accountable for outcomes prior to No Child Left Behind. Whether you like No Child Left Behind or not, it did force us to expect all students to be proficient and it did hold schools accountable for student outcomes and we saw big improvements there.

[02:11:18] We're not just looking at degrees and what we're putting into schools but what's actually coming out of them. So when I talk about school accountability and I think about school accountability, the thing you want to do is to define and measure what matters and then to clearly communicate those results so parents, policymakers, the public can interpret them clearly, transparently, and intuitively.

[02:11:41] You want a system that people can really understand what's happening. Both Florida and Mississippi have implemented an A-Ref school grading system. I know A-Ref is very politically charged. It is in every state that we work in for school accountability.

[02:12:13] Currently, 14 states use an A-Ref system. None of them are identical. but the really good ones that are producing results all abide by these nine fundamental principles. The first one is probably the most politically charged of those, it's making sure that you're using a rating that is clear and transparent.

[02:12:32] Florida had a school accountability well before they implemented their A through F system in 1999, they used to rate them on performance descriptors of high performing, performing, low performing and critically low performing. Then they moved to Roman numerals, which was great 'cause Lisa was five, one, two, three, four, five.

[02:12:51] Not everybody knows what a Roman numeral is 'cause, well, math's important too. And they don't always know whether or not a one or a five is the best. So that was another challenge. Or how many Roman numerals we were actually using. So '99, they switched to A through F school letter grade.

[02:13:08] That made a big difference in the outcomes of performance. So when I was there in '99, we issued school letter grades for the first time, rigorous accountability system. We issued more DNF school letter grades than we did A and B letter grades. So it's pretty controversial.

[02:13:25] Got a lot of negative phone calls. Be able to get a lot of constituent calls. But because our system was transparent and easy to understand, we were able to explain why a school was graded, what it was, and what went into it. And you'll see that three years later, we didn't change our expectations for students.

[02:13:42] We didn't change our rating system. We didn't change how we graded schools. And those trends reversed. So knowing and understanding what was expected of schools made a big difference in how they reacted and what action they actually produced in the buildings. Grading's got outcomes that are both academically proven, proven with NAEP data, and also supported by public opinion. A lot of public opinion polling on school accountability. People like to be able to understand what the grading system says. The second fundamental principle is the harder one.

[02:14:17] This one is really trying to pick your objective, concise student learning outcomes. What indicators do you want to hold schools accountable for? Really strong models include things very simply, objective, proficiency on state assessments, growth on state assessments, proficiency and progress of English language acquisition assessments, if you have English learners, graduation rates, and college and career measures.

[02:14:48] And those college and career measures really focused on are kids earning college credit while they're still in school? they scoring college ready on the act and sat the really strong accountability systems don't focus a lot on the input measures such as parental satisfaction or attendance or anything that isn't within the guise of objective outcomes related to student learning these are all really important things to capture to give contextualization about the school accountability system

[02:15:23] and should be reported along with the school's rating regarding school outcomes but when you're selecting indicators for your school accountability systems you should really be focusing on things that are meaningful to the student so if you're selecting an indicator does that mean something to the student so does being proficient on a reading test lead to better later in later in school and later in life

outcomes yeah it does we would argue that kids that can read are a lot better off when they leave school you should also be sure that your indicators are valid reliable

[02:15:58] and accurate are you able to collect information that is measuring what you want it to can you reliably collect it time and time again and is it accurate in the way it's being reported you want to make sure that you have those features in the indicator so you can be using them for comparisons state to state if they're not valid and reliable or accurate make some comparisons statewide difficult you should also have indicators that relate to student achievement and you also want to make sure that they differentiate among the schools selecting an indicator and we find this

[02:16:35] with attendance a lot selecting an indicator like attendance all schools are earning all the points on most attendance measures because kids generally show up to school and the threshold that they set for attendance isn't that high so if the score the attendance indicator is worth 10 points most schools are earning nine or ten points on it so it's not really differentiating what the performance of the school is so it's kind of a i don't want to say a throwaway indicator but more of a contextual indicator that you could report but doesn't add a lot of information to your system you also want to hold schools accountable only for things that are within their control so if they don't have

[02:17:15] control over how much money they get per student you can't hold them accountable for that if they don't have control over technology in their building you can't hold them accountable for that so you should only be holding schools accountable for things that are within their control when you're thinking about indicators and you decide oh this sounds like a great indicator you want to make sure that there aren't any perverse incentives that might result for that and what i mean by that is school safety was a big discussion about indicators and so some schools or states wanted to include the number of expulsions as part of their school accountability system

[02:17:54] sounds great but if you're going to be docked points for having more expulsions you're going to be less likely to expel a student and if you're less likely to expel them perhaps it's creating a dangerous environment for the rest of the students in that school so you have to be careful that any of the indicators that you select won't result in perverse actions that are actually going to do the opposite of what you're trying to impact um and we don't want to have too many indicators in an accountability system that really dilute what's important which are the student outcome

[02:18:32] measures so you don't want to add so many things that things get lost in the shuffle and aren't meaningful there's also a consideration for collecting data we heard about 45-minute surveys every month to get real-time data which is great but that's a survey thing if you are trying to collect information and schools have to report information every single month for an hour up to the state who's going to collect it to use it as an accountability indicator you have to have a system to collect it a system to qc it a system to create it is it worth the time and money to

[02:19:09] collect that indicator to get the information that you actually want to derive out of that indicator so if you don't have something and you're trying to collect it just make sure that the administrative work of it doesn't outweigh the benefits of actually having that information and then obviously you want to make sure it's aligned to your state's overall policy goals um we also talk about making sure that systems are based on proficiency and growth you don't want a system that's focused only on proficiency because that seems to be in some schools correlated highly with

[02:19:47] economic indicators and students that aren't coming to school prepared to learn especially in your elementary grades but you also don't want a system that's focused entirely on growth because you want to make sure that students are actually achieving something and that they're going to be ready for life after high school and so you want to make sure that you have a level playing field you might want to weight growth a little bit more in elementary school with still a focus on proficiency and growth maybe a little bit less in high school because you're really focused on making sure they're going to be ready when they leave so this is about as simple as it gets is

[02:20:26] pretty close to what florida does for their accountability system balance half on proficiency half on growth proficiency is just what percent of students are proficient on ela math science and social studies. And then looking at growth, it's what percent of students are making at least a year's worth of progress in a year's worth of time. Each of the indicators are worth 100 points. Nothing outweighs or outshines something else. And then we also have a progress

[02:20:56] of a low 25% indicator. We talked a lot about, sorry, I'll get back to that. That's the conversation you were having in the last presentation. High schools, same thing. Each of them are 100 point indicators you might want to add a college and career acceleration or readiness indicator add a graduation rate indicator notice for your graduation rate you want to hold schools accountable for what you want to happen not necessarily what is happening so your school accountability system should be aspirational and expectations are if you want

[02:21:33] kids to be proficient hold schools accountable for kids being proficient don't hold them accountable for partially proficient proficient and advanced if you want students to graduate in four years hold them accountable for a four-year graduation rate not a five-year rate or a six-year rate so set your expectations of what you want to happen for a student kind of your best case scenario and that's what you should be holding schools accountable for what's the career college in career acceleration what is that data point so for that one florida and mississippi both use

[02:22:09] in a lot of other states too the percent of students that are scoring three or better on ap four or better on ib earning an industry certification by passing the assessment earning dual credit courses with a beer better in core subjects and what percent of kids are doing that For the other readiness ones, it's what percent of students are scoring college ready on ACT.

[02:22:40] So Mississippi has what percent of students are scoring a 22 or higher on math, 22 or higher on ELA, 18 or higher on reading. - Is there anything for a dual enrollment in high school, dual enrollment in college courses also?

[02:22:55] - Correct. - Have you had an opportunity to look at our college and career readiness indicator and do you know whether it's basically the same are significant differences i have i can actually show you i have a slide at the very very end away after everything else i'll wait i won't get to it but yes you look at a lot of the same indicators but it's not as robust and it does not provide um it's not as rigorous of an expectation so the way the calculation is isn't just what percent of kids earned an advanced or an acceleration

[02:23:32] or what percent of kids are college ready it's what percent of kids compared to um measurable objective compared to this and then it's given a rating so i can show it to you um afterwards or at the break exactly how it's calculated so that's one of the key points though that you bring up is you want something that's transparent you want people to be able to look at the system and say oh 65 of kids earned a college

credit when they were in high school that's pretty cool or 40% of kids are college ready based on ACT college board expectations on SAT.

[02:24:08] So being able to say what percent of kids are accomplishing something is key in the transparency of your system as well. It enables people to access it, ask questions about it, and it also gives a lot of face validity to your system. When you say this is a B school or this is a D school, why? Let's look at the data and find out.

[02:24:29] this is another key to strong accountability systems is the way you calculate growth also matters there are two general ways of calculating growth in a school accountability calculation one is criterion based or standards based where you're looking at is the student moving from a lower level to a higher level on your state assessment so are they going from below basic to basic basic to proficient, or they're increasing by a certain number of scale score points that will eventually

[02:25:03] lead them to be proficient in a certain amount of time. That's a criterion-based system that ensures that if the school is getting credit for the growth the student is making, that that growth is meaningful to the student. There are also normative growth measures that are used in school accountability, like EVOS, value-added models in general, student growth percentiles that look at whether or not students are making more growth than their peers. It doesn't necessarily mean

[02:25:36] because I'm making more growth than McKinsey that I'm going to eventually be proficient. It just means I'm doing better than somebody else. And those might not be as meaningful to students, especially in cases like 2022 where you're going to see declines in performance, probably declines in student individual student growth and making sure that that growth if the school is getting credited for it is actually meaningful to students and there's a lot of reasons to measure growth to proficient or advanced one you're setting learning expectations and you're able to measure them

[02:26:16] and if you do measure them that students will eventually reach that proficient and advanced level two in a criterion-based system all students could conceivably demonstrate that they've made growth if you set your expectation and all students move up an achievement level all students will get credit for it in a normative system not everyone can get credit because they're constantly being compared to their peers so if somebody makes growth that means somebody else didn't there are also criteria for determining individual growth is set expectations are known before the

[02:26:51] school year with normative systems all of that comes after the test is given and it's all relying on student level data thrown into a calculation and then in result is provided at the end of the year and the expectations in one year might be a little bit different than they were in the last year but you won't know that until after the school year is over do you have could you give one or two examples of like the criterion based and then in the norm referenced base sure so for criterion based growth it would be an example of a student was at below basic one year and they're

[02:27:30] at basic the next year so the criteria is that they cross up to a higher achievement level or it could be students are a student is 100 points away from being proficient they have to make 35 33 points of growth each year for the next three years in order to be proficient and if they meet 33 points of growth in one year the school gets credit for them making growth so it's a criteria that you set that says if a student does x the school gets credit for that growth and it's based on however you set to make sure that that student gets to proficient

[02:28:09] and if the student does meet that growth year over year they will get to proficient normative systems on the other hand look at whether or not my growth exceeded an expectation or for value-added modeling if i'm a student achieving at this particular level compared to all of my peers who are at this particular level we are expected to make four points of growth just on average so that's our expected growth if i make more than four points of growth i've added

[02:28:44] value so i've made five points of growth i'm doing better than what you expected me to so i'd get credit for that what it doesn't do is say will five points of growth get me to proficient or advanced all it's saying is i did better than what you expected me to because my peers did four points and i did five points and so those systems where you're comparing peers you're creating a system that has guaranteed winners and guaranteed not winners and not all students will make growth

[02:29:19] in those normative systems so it's important to look at not just you know can all students achieve it are expectations set and will that growth that they make be meaningful you're just looking at whether or not they're doing better than their peers and in cases where hypothetically statewide performance goes down across the board it could be that students that regress but regress less than their peers the school is credited with growth and so that's not an outcome that's meaningful to

[02:29:52] students but they did better than their peer even though they're not making growth towards proficient or advanced achievement so really think about how you want to measure growth that's meaningful to students you can measure it a lot of different ways but strong systems that measure it with expectations that this is what we expect students to do to be proficient to be advanced to move across an achievement level has really gotten some results it also allows for longitudinal comparisons if you're measuring using criterion-based growth the expectations will eventually

[02:30:32] result in proficiency if they're consistently met year after year and educators can generally replicate and produce their growth if you're using a criterion-based method if you're using a normative method you can't replicate that at your site level school level or even district level because it relies on state level data which you don't have access to um this is one i think worth a little um a little bit more conversation because you talked about what to do with the lowest of the low performing kids you know mark talked about them as being your below basic red

[02:31:10] flag you know group this is this is what we're trying to do with this indicator um florida and mississippi and a number of other states have created a lowest performing growth category for students so they have a criterion-based growth system that says at the beginning of the year students in that school the lowest quartile of the students in that school based on prior performance are their own indicator because we want schools to focus on making sure that lowest performing group of students makes progress every single year and they're double

[02:31:46] counted because they're counted in the lowest performing group and they're counted in the all growth group so they're counted twice for growth which means that they have to provide extra focus on it a reason a lot of the states that i've worked in have done this is because it focuses on kids that truly need the help and attention rather than arbitrarily demographic race groups or free and reduced price lunch groups because we already demonstrated there are kids in all of those groups that are proficient and not just focusing on those but focusing on the kids that truly need the help rather than the demographics and also because it

[02:32:24] helps students or schools not just focus on those what people call the bubble kids I'm sure you've heard that before those kids that are just below proficient this ensures that they're focusing on the lowest performing kids and you know not just getting credit for moving kids from just below proficient to that proficient level because the system relies so heavily on proficiency or doesn't incentivize growth enough for them to focus on those lowest performing kids so having a separate indicator that focuses on the lowest performing kids was really important in these systems so it

[02:33:01] rises the tide every school has a lowest performing 25 percent and it's all based on prior year scores so you know the beginning of the year which are your lowest performing kids that need that extra focus in your are going to get that extra focus in your accountability system um and then the last ones are pretty simple make sure your reporting results the close to the end of the school year as possible we want to make sure people are acting on them reporting them in november december you know people want to do that but if you report them in the summer you have time for professional

[02:33:36] development opportunities hirings strategic thinking about curriculum and implementation for the next year at the school level so you want to get that information into the hands of educators and parents right away at the beginning of the summer so they can make plans also need to clearly communicate this to parents. You want to have a system that parents can understand. They're a pretty big consumer of education in addition to the general public. Want to be able to be sure that they understand what the system is made of, why we're holding students accountable for it,

[02:34:09] and how it will help their student in the school year. And also, even if you have all the best indicators and have all the great calculations, if you set a grading scale that 90% of your schools earn an A or your top rating at the end of the year, you've kind of done it all for naught because then you're really not taking it seriously. So you want to establish an aspirational yet attainable grading scale. And we also encourage to add an automatic increase in that grading scale.

[02:34:40] So if 65% of schools earn an A or a B in 2017, in 2018, expectation for earning an A or B goes up by 5%. That way, you're constantly raising a bar. It's not a political decision. It's making sure that we're continuing to ratchet up standards and expectations, but meeting schools where they're at right now with an end goal that's aspirational, but yet attainable because it's only improving or changing when we're doing it. And it's been really not subject to politics or election years, as we heard in the last presentation, because it just automatically

[02:35:17] happens. And then finally, you want to reward schools that have done good things educating kids. So we set up school recognition programs in these states where schools that improve a rating or earn the highest rating in the current year get additional recognition dollars that bypasses collective bargaining, bypasses district set aside, and we intend it to be used for teacher bonuses.

[02:35:45] so they get a hundred dollars per student that goes directly to the school if they improve their letter grade so go from a d to an f um f to a d wrong way f to a d d to a c um the school gets to decide how they want to spend that money the legislative intent is teacher bonuses staff bonuses they did a great job throughout the year let's get a little extra money into their pocket but they could also be used for non-recurring expenditures so if they wanted to buy some new technology or make an improvement in school playground equipment or something they could do that too you also want to use this for interventions you know you talked about what

[02:36:21] what should virginia be doing interventions that's a key that's the whole other thing that comes after getting the information and we have a lot of policy solutions for that too and and provide support for the students and schools that are struggling so it has an impact if you have a strong transparent rating system it does improve student outcomes we've seen that with nape data we've seen that with academic research we know parents like them i always use the example of increased parent involvement oklahoma graded schools in their first year and they had 25 000 more hits on their website than they did kids in the school system so it's not just parents using

[02:37:01] information people just want to know what's happening in the public schools and if you can make it transparent accessible for them it makes a big difference it also changes the focus on action i said what what action do you want to inspire at this beginning of the meeting in leon county which is tallahassee florida they dedicated an entire school board meeting how to be the first district not to have a c school in their district and they spent a whole meeting talking about that wasn't about bus schedules or lunch schedules or anything else it was talking about what kind of interventions and supports can we put in place and i think that's the key to the school accountability systems is having something that's understandable meaningful

[02:37:39] that can inspire action at the local level you need some good state policy solutions but you also know that your districts and schools do a lot of good things too they just need to know what they should be doing and we if you expect you lay out what you expect them to do graduate kids in four years get kids to proficiency and then hold them accountable for those results in the end education is an economic and societal prosperity indicator it's a leading indicator We know it impacts so many people beyond parents and the students that are there, but it impacts

[02:38:15] educators, administrators, the public, business leaders, policymakers. A lot of the talks I get to do are to the business community, chambers of commerce of the state, you know, business partnerships. They want to know what's happening. Public wants to know what's happening to their tax dollars. All of these things, having transparent information and really demonstrating your returning on your investment in education is great for the state. And then finally, if there's anything that you liked here, if you're looking for solutions, I invite you to join us in Salt Lake City, November 16th to 18th. We do our National Education Summit out there. We usually have about

[02:38:51] a thousand policymakers and high-level officials out there. We haven't made any announcement about who all our speakers are, but there might be some Virginia speakers on some panels out there. It would be great to have you out there. If you're interested, either go to this website or talk to and I can help you get set up for three fantastic days in salt lake city it's it's actually the date of our of our next well you can all vote to change it we could next year i'm sure there are some

[02:39:28] questions i have to say this was very one of the few encouraging things since i've been on this board that i've i've heard so this is a great presentation thank you thank you very much i'll i'll kick it off with just a couple of questions that arose during the last meeting and these will be thematic kind of an amalgamation if you will number one this year what we saw in virginia's accreditation system is that it really didn't respond to the learning loss that was experienced as a result

[02:40:07] of school closures for lots of different reasons but i was wondering if you could talk a little bit about just maybe fundamentally or philosophically how an accreditation or accountability system at the state level should respond to learn to the learning loss that we've experienced as a as a result of the last

few years and um maybe how we should think proactively hopefully we'll never have anything like that again but how we should think proactively about accountability systems and accreditation systems responding to different external events

[02:40:44] and then um the second question is uh you know actually i'll just leave it there that's a big one get get things started it is a big one um most states don't conflate their accreditation and accountability systems in most states accreditation is are they following the rules and doing things that they're supposed to be doing from a legal compliance standpoint and for doing right by kids

[02:41:16] and accountability is are kids learning you know are they doing their job making sure students are improving their outcomes and focusing on all the accreditation stuff is important vitally but takes away from what we should be doing to make sure students respond to or schools respond to those education outcomes when you start providing transparent data about what is actually happening in the schools it makes a big difference um and i'm not going to pick on your system but i'm just

[02:41:54] going to give you an example of how florida and mississippi rate their indicators on percent of students proficient compared to what virginia does at the state and federal level so in florida if you say for math achievement what's what did florida do i'd say oh x 34 of kids are proficient in this school. That's the indicator. School earned 34 points for that. In Virginia, in your state accreditation system, you take the rate of the students who passed plus students who showed

[02:42:26] growth and English learners who showed growth on language proficiency and then looked at that percent to see whether or not it was greater than or equal to 75 percent in reading or if the prior year level two with failure rates decreased by greater than or equal to 10 percent. And then you give them a level and so you say it's a level one two or a three after you're comparing it a multiple

[02:42:56] a multi a multi um yeah it's a multi-tier indicator with multiple pieces of information in it so if you said what's virginia's um you know what's the school's math achievement and i'm like level three like okay explain that so then you have to try and backtrack and explain what it means to be a level three or what it means to be a level one and you lose a lot of people with that and there's no urgency in being a level three there is an urgency when there's 34 percent of kids proficient so i

[02:43:35] think that's kind of the difference of if you're not getting external action or responding with intervention to the systems it's because you're telling most people more than 75 percent of students are proficient you know what was it 75 to 83 percent of kids were proficient in fourth and eighth grade reading and math on sols so there's no urgency there and then you're telling them they're a level one two or three based on 75 percent or greater 66 percent or decreases in them and then a level one two or three i don't even know i mean i know because i looked at the system

[02:44:11] is one good or three good yeah both baseball you know you don't know which one's better And then for the federal system, which is same information, similar information, completely different type of calculation for academic achievement is percent of kids passing in the current year or in three years compared to the long-term goals.

[02:44:36] So you're looking at a multi-year average or a single year, whichever is better. And then you're comparing it to a target that was sent that you have to go look up to see what the target was. So I don't know if that's good or not.

[02:44:52] You either met your indicator or you didn't. So I think that's part of the transparency piece of it is making sure you as a board member can easily explain this on your way down to the ground floor as you're walking to your car. And that would be a challenge. And that's, I think, why there's not a lot of urgency is people don't understand it. Public doesn't understand it. It's harder to get media to write about it in a simple way. And so there's no urgency to act on it because people don't understand that the situation is a little more dire than we need to, because all we're looking

[02:45:31] at is those overall rankings of Virginia is generally in the top 10. You're right. So is Massachusetts. They also have more higher education institutions per capita than any other state in the nation, very white, and high economic status there. I mean, they're going to have high performance rankings. But when you dig into the data and actually see what's happening with black, Hispanic, economically disadvantaged students, the story is usually a little bit different. So how did Florida students do overall? How did they do overall? In the pandemic, you know,

[02:46:08] I'm looking at the Florida website and I guess they lost 3% of their grade A schools, right? Which doesn't seem like a lot, frankly, if they had Virginia style learning loss. So did they just not have the learning loss or did their system also mask this some way florida didn't change anything in their system um they did have a big decrease in performance in 2021 they tested more than 95 of their kids so we know that those were those were good results it rebounded we're not

[02:46:42] back to pre-pandemic status yet in 2022 which is why i think our nape results might not be exactly at the 19 levels that we had seen but they're coming back and they're coming back pretty strong mississippi on the other hand are back to their 2019 pre-pandemic results in the two years they also tested more than 95 of their kids in 2021 so we have good information on them go ahead a couple of a point and then a question for you beck if you um go to your slide um on virginia's

[02:47:21] accountability, the accreditation, the graduation rate. I absolutely agree with you that the public, when you're talking about a graduation rate, they expect for that to be the percentage of kids that graduate. Whereas in our calculation and the way that we work things, that's not exactly the truth.

[02:47:45] So I think there's a lot to be discussed about those particular points, right? Like it's not and and the dropout rate same way like we if we're talking about an indicator it needs to be that the graduation rate period um the second thing that i'd just like your input on is um uh in virginia during the pandemic we went through a process of holding our schools harmless through the accreditation system i'd just like to get your feedback on what you think about that and and where we go from that so i blame the usde for that because they said you can do it so pretty much

[02:48:25] every state did it right um florida uh did take advantage i think it pretty much every state in the nation took advantage of that it was a 2021 provision florida still calculated school grades but only issued them to schools that wanted them so if you're a school that earned an a you'd want your grade if you're a school that improved you'd want your grade so that um i wouldn't it's going it's it's coming back schools have to be held accountable this year so it's coming back after essentially three years two years of no grades in the third year of um schooling so it's going

[02:49:02] to be hard coming back and putting those back out but florida did it and mississippi did it and a bunch of other states have done it since then um to put out their systems and arguably it's really important to do because you have to know where to provide your supports and resources so but a challenge and thanks for coming this was great uh and i heard that we're gonna have a board meeting in utah in

november and go skiing afterwards i was very excited to i was very excited to hear that i feel like it's a day actually for mother rotherham if you are serious about that we can arrange for everybody to be in utah for those three days and have separate meeting space for

[02:49:42] you on monday and tuesday if you want it or even tuesday wednesday just let me know um i have two questions one uh you talked about you want to have a bar and then it goes up at a certain point so a certain number of schools getting an a you raise it five percent was your example educators complain about that i think it's a complaint that has some merit that like well it seems like we're always no one's getting there we're sort of arbitrarily deciding how many schools are going to get different grades so like what's the argument for that versus just setting a really high bar and when schools are there then thinking about things like earned autonomy for them other things once

[02:50:18] they hit that bar but having it almost like more of like a proficiency based than like a normed model if you will as we think about for students like so there's a standard it's it's there it's attainable and once you're there that's great you get to do other stuff so i get that depends on where you want to set it right um i worked in one state where they were insistent that the bar had to be 90 proficient or 90 out of 100 to earn an a and when you looked at the percent of kids that were proficient in reading and math because they had rigorous expectations for kids they would have zero a schools so you want you want your scale to be reflective of what an a should

[02:50:55] look like um i get changing the bar all the time um it's terrible but at least it's done based on merit right rather than based on other things florida did when they set up their accountability system for schools that continuously earned a's they got a lot more flexibility and freedoms in what they're supposed to do. They became charter districts or charter, not in the sense of charter schools, but they just got more autonomy and flexibility in how they used funds, who was being

[02:51:27] coached and stuff. But the reason we had this automatic increase put into place is because we kept seeing stagnation in Florida. So you see in the first few years, like that first three years, we didn't do anything to change the bar like we set the expectation and we clearly set it really high if we had more dnfs than we did a or b schools and then after three years you know it flipped around but then we started to kind of plateau for a few years so we had to make things more rigorous so you can do that multiple ways one way the easiest way is just changing your grading scale a hard way is changing your state assessment so we went through two state assessment

[02:52:06] changes from fcat to fcat 2.0 to fsa and now we're in the process of going to a third or fourth assessment now under the grading system. So changing grading system or testing systems and raising expectations of what it means to be proficient is another way to raise the expectations.

[02:52:22] But systems change every year. And the reason the automatic increase is it's planned. So it's not like you're surprising or changing on schools. You tell them this is what's going to happen if we start hitting some of those plateaus. But I get what you mean. I want to set a high bar, but it's trying to meet the schools where they're at and having that aspirational yet attainable piece. It's hard to balance. Okay. And I kind of lie. I sort of have three questions. First was a compound. What about labeling schools? We hear a lot of objections. You're like, well, you're labeling schools. People aren't going to want to open a business or move to a school where there's

[02:53:00] a D school or whatever. How do you like, you've seen this around this sort of approach, whether it's any kind of label of any Roman numerals or whatever, talk about that. How should we think

That's an objection you hear a lot. How should we think about that? Yeah, I hear it all the time. That's what I probably get beat up the most on.

[02:53:17] Everyone likes principles two through nine. They don't like principle one. But principle one is what people understand, right? I mean, we saw this in Florida. We had categorical descriptors. We moved to Roman numerals. We weren't seeing any improvements. We were in the bottom 10 on every possible ranking you could imagine, from NAEP to dropout to graduation, and things were slipping.

[02:53:38] And so we had to do something that caught the public's attention for good and for bad. Like, people got really mad about it, but it made a difference in school results. So it was just that consistent effort. We also have had, just in Florida, two very comprehensive research projects done.

[02:53:58] You probably know David Figlio and Jane Hathaway out at Urban. they did a big study in florida on whether or not a through f letter grading changed teacher behavior and it actually did i mean in a positive way they started focusing more on what matter for student level outcomes they focused less on things that weren't always relevant like not as much time planning the school day talking about school lunch those types of things so it really changed their

[02:54:31] behaviors to be very positive. The other one is Manhattan Institute did, this is probably the most interesting one, New York City schools graded A through F under Joel Klein. They did it for eight years. Then Bloomberg came in, abolished the program, and Manhattan Institute looked at the effects of A through F during his tenure, and then once it was repealed, all of those effects went went away. There was positive effects throughout the A through F. As soon as they changed to a

[02:55:07] different label and different rating systems, all of those ceased. It's just something people understand. Nobody likes it, but they understand it. And in Florida, I kind of kidded. I was there in 99 and 2000 and 2001 fielding constituent calls of literally people just angry about the school grade. It's not fair. How can you do this to my teachers? These are good teachers. These are of people. And I would bring them to our report card that literally looked like this. And we walked through it. And I'm like, 17% of kids in this school can read proficiently. Is that an A

[02:55:45] school? And so the face validity of these transparent calculations really got people to be like, oh, yeah, you're right. I mean, that's not good news. And so being able to clearly explain, you know, are kids making a year's worth of progress in a year's worth of time? Did they move from basic to proficient what what's happening in those schools really made a difference so it's stigmatizing for good or bad um but what we've seen is good for students bad for adults adults hate them doesn't affect kids so my okay that's really helpful thank you my last question

[02:56:20] builds on on dr ballo's question i think what we are wrestling with is we have this accreditation system that's been an account of it that's been an accountability system in effect but it's hard to make an accreditation system and i think it's i'll just speak for myself i think it distorts our ability to finance schools well distorts our politics it's like if there's a bunch of problems but we don't have an alternative right now and accreditation is a serious thing is like you've taken you can't just willy-nilly take accreditation away from schools because there's just enormous consequences so it by definition has to be kind of slow and and plotting and and all of that so just how we've got the federal requirements we live under with essa we've got the accreditation system

[02:56:59] and then we could build some sort of an accountability system where you're talking about or something else like how should we think about like best practices how those three things fit because that that's all it's a lot of pieces and so like what would you suggest in terms of there does have to be some sort of crosswalk right like if a school's really not doing well does that call into question accreditation and so forth like it just seems complicated to stitch these together in a way that's going to make sense to people it's a good question

[02:57:27] In Mississippi, they have accreditation as well. Their accreditation and accountability technical manual is like 200 and some pages. Their accountability system is like 20 pages of it, and it's reported completely separate from their accreditation system, even though the accountability system is listed in their standards of accreditation.

[02:57:50] And so they've just made the conscious decision at the department that the accountability part of it for student outcomes is given its separate own due with its own website, its own accountability task force that I sit on, its own governing rules, its own press.

[02:58:12] I mean, it's completely separate. Most schools in Mississippi are accredited. They meet all the legal requirements and are doing all the right things. Not most schools in Mississippi are A schools yet. I mean, it's just being clear that they're two completely different things. The federal thing's a whole other monster. What I would say is change your federal system. I mean, it's not out of the question. States do it all the time.

[02:58:39] I've been a federal peer reviewer every single round since Duncan, all the way through for federal peer review. States want to make big changes to their system. As long as you're complying with federal law, you can do that. You're basically identifying schools for supports and interventions. That's the purpose of ESSA and your purpose of your federal accountability systems. And you can do that with your state system. And both of the systems I talk about meet federal compliance. So should we try to integrate that as what you're saying? So we essentially have two systems, not three. Is that, am I hearing you right? That's what I would do,

[02:59:11] but big lift. Thank you for this. Very helpful. One, I have one, that's maybe a category of follow-up to Mr. one of Mr. Rotherham's questions how do you do you have a problem with attracting and retaining highly effective teachers to your D and F schools and if you do see a problem what do you do about it at either state or local level how do you counter that is that a problem and how do you counter it so one you have to have a good evaluation system to know if teachers are effective

[02:59:46] so that's your first thing which Florida does they have a teacher value-added system that I've worked for the last 12 years that essentially tells you whether or not they're effective in the school that they're teaching in in the current or the last three years um and what florida law did i'm not necessarily suggesting this was required that dnf schools hire more highly effective teachers and so but i mean how do you incentivize our struggling schools are desperate to hire more effective teachers and can't get them can't get them to come can't get them to stay and they and

[03:00:23] And our most challenged schools have less money than our more successful schools. So is there something in the state funding formula that gives those schools more money to hire those teachers? It doesn't give them more money necessarily to hire more teachers, but lots of districts offer incentive bonuses.

[03:00:42] So they're all within the same district. So Miami-Dade County, third largest district in the country, will pay you more if you teach in a DNF school than if you do in an A or B school over there. you have you don't have districts that are so i don't know how many districts you have or divisions you have 67. you have 67 and your state is much bigger than ours population wise so i'm not quite sure how comparable to our 130 jurisdictions but we've got a number of jurisdictions in virginia that the whole jurisdiction essentially would be df schools if we had your kind of rating so it's not like they can allocate the teachers within their division they are losing their strong

[03:01:20] teachers to wealthier divisions so how do you all not have maybe maybe the size of your districts means that more intra-district movement is the solution no because in florida where i'm at down there there's just three school district um it's incentivizing them with living conditions and money and loan forgiveness so florida has loan forgiveness programs districts incentivize we pay more for incentivize for high demand fields so you know if you're a math teacher or a science

[03:01:56] teacher how about your your do you pay more for your school are there do you have divisions districts that have a high percentage of df schools and do they somehow get more financial support from the state or do they have more local capacity they don't get more financial support for the state to hire teachers but the way the allocation works out dnf schools in florida end up with about a thousand dollars more per kid in funding not because of a cognizant effort of sending more money to dnf schools but because of the way the funding formula works for allocations

[03:02:33] to title one schools so that it just happens that they have a little more money and and i'm sorry but if I may, one last funding question. So do you know what the state local percentage is? What's the balance in funding between states and locality, between the state and localities in Florida? I can't speak to that. Here, you know, we have an issue where we have significantly more of the money coming from the localities rather than from the state.

[03:03:00] Yeah, I can't answer questions about the Florida Education Finance Program. I knew it 20 years ago. I don't know it now. Thank you. You gave me way more than I knew already. mr president i was taking notes connecting it to our previous conversations as we talked about a credit exercise some observations i had three questions your answer one uh but you kind of created a fourth but you might want to email me that so you know i we talked previously your slide 24 about the principles you know that was something that we talked previously about that uh that andy brought up about you know the principles piece thought that was great you mentioned attendance is context not accountability and context is important and families and people and schools

[03:03:37] want to see context so that that was pretty good the importance of avoiding perverse actions uh very very powerful uh the fact that the indicators are weighted some indicators are more important than others some are just context some are important but even then they're not equally important uh i love how your slides 27 and 28 talk about the progress for the lowest 25 percent uh that again incentivizing moving that uh very very important um the the fact that moving the lowest 25% also kind of makes the conversation more about just the individual student. And you talked about how that is about individual children, not about necessarily race or socioeconomic status

[03:04:14] or those types of things. So that was very interesting. There is a trigger to increase the grading scale. Thank you for sharing that. That was something I was curious about. My question that you answered was about the accreditation versus accountability when you said most states do not conflate accreditation

accountability and so i know that's a conversation you know about decoupling the two and and and what that would look like so i appreciate that the one that i don't think you have time to answer for me that i'd like to maybe send me a link to is the evolution of fcat fcat 2.0 to fsl etc because um if you've truly changed the assessments or like we've done in virginia

[03:04:53] we keep tweaking the assessments and so i think that's uh the engine under the hood is very important so finally to my questions um and you kind of talked about what does the state like florida mississippi do for f the d schools what does the state do um what does the governing board do for df schools i miss holton's questions about funding very very appropriate but again back to essa we've got to go address our lowest performing schools what what is being done for dnf schools specifically for dnf schools we don't they have to write intervention plans requirement of federal law so they have to have a school improvement plan most schools have school

[03:05:30] improvement plans anyway these are just under more scrutiny by the florida state board of education so they are under a lot of scrutiny by the state department when i was there and i believe they still do this is um every school that was rated an f was given a department contact that if they had a question even if it wasn't your area of expertise they could call you and you would help get them the help and the support and the answers they needed and so in so as they were building their school improvement plan and they wanted to do specific things and they had questions about where can i get resources about k3 literacy screeners you're like oh i'm the accountability

[03:06:07] person but you're my school that i'm the contact with i can find that information to you um and get that information that you need in order to get free literacy screeners for your particular districts goodbye mr hanson um okay thank you thank you then um tell me succinctly probably not possible what are the measures you're using for achievement versus growth is it the same end of year achievement tests that you're using both for um or do you have different assessments uh what what

[03:06:42] what how does that and is it just that once a year assessment same assessment once a year so then my then i guess the fourth question again is what what what how is the assessment system how the How do assessments change from FCAT to FCAT 2.0 to what you're heading to?

[03:06:59] So you might know a lot of states change their standards, and as they do that, they have to change their assessments. So Mark even talked about that a little bit with long-term trend versus main NAEP. Long-term trends still test the same things they tested 50 years ago. Same information, same concept, same way of testing. They're doing the same thing that they did. Maine NAEP has evolved, but has maintained that longitudinal comparison piece. So as we get new information about best ways to teach reading, as we get new information about best ways to teach math, as we get new information in the fields, we're able to change the assessment to keep up

[03:07:39] with the times so that education in 2020 looks different than when those tests were first administered in 1990. So they've changed to be computer-based. They're not given on paper, pencil anymore they're looking now towards moving to automated scoring for writing exams so just keeping up with the times in the content they just did a big standards re framework or NAEP framework for reading a couple of years ago that updated a lot of the things in the reading framework to be

[03:08:10] you know more universal touch on more science of reading type things to touch on more informational text, the type of things kids are reading, what they're reading about. So it's just making sure

that those frameworks kind of stay up to date. In Florida, we do the same thing. And we also raised expectations along the way. Prior to FCAT, we had the high school competency test, the HSTC.

[03:08:37] Florida's one of the first states to have a graduation exit exam requirement, which still exists today. HSCT was a minimum competency eighth grade assessment that kids had to pass before they graduated from high school. Didn't think that was a good idea because it's not preparing kids once they leave high school. So they switched to the FCAT. So it's for comprehensive assessment. They changed some of their standards. They made it a criterion-based assessment, required it for exit exams for 10th graders. So now you had to pass a 10th grade skills test in order to improve or in order to graduate from high school. Again, they changed to FCAT 2.0 as they're starting to develop online assessments, being more rigorous in their content,

[03:09:15] more rigorous in their expectations. And so FCAT 2.0 came along and ratcheted up. So when we went from FCAT to FCAT 2.0, the percent of students scoring proficient at each grade and subject dropped between 10 and 20 percent, depending on the grade and subject. So much higher bar for students and accountability systems had to adjust from that. Went up to FSA, Florida Standards assessment. So that is the next generation standards that Florida implemented. Florida again revised their standards to the BEST standards, and they're now going to be administering

[03:09:53] the FAST test, which is going to be computer adaptive online assessment that they're working towards. So each time they implement a new assessment is kind of to keep up with the times to refresh the content. You don't want to get locked into a vendor for 20-year lifespan ban of a contract for something. So it's just making sure that they're keeping up with what's happening and each time making sure that they're raising expectations for kids. I think one of the keys for accountability systems is making sure that all of the outcomes are meaningful for kids and you want to have high expectations for kids and then give on what you consider to be an A, B

[03:10:29] or C. As we heard Mr. Rotherham say, you know, that's why you don't set it at 90 percent is because you wanna have a high proficiency expectation where you don't have 90% of your kids necessarily scoring proficient because it's not a rigorous assessment.

[03:10:44] So high expectations for kids, be willing to give just a little bit on your A through F system or your star rating system or your color rating system, whatever you decide to go with in the beginning. - Thank you.

[03:11:00] - Question about, can you speak about what kind of acceleration or gifted and talented programs are done? can't speak to that but i can get you more information if you want i think it may be it we really appreciate the time and the information you know we will be moving through this work pretty soon and i'm sure we'll be in touch with you thank you raising your hand so thank you so

[03:11:38] thank you so much thank you it's my pleasure all right you guys want to take a break or you want to move on five minutes all right we'll do five

[03:24:21] yeah we got a lot we have the overview of supports provided to local school divisions by osq dr ortiz and i know you're going to make introductions now right yes sir all right good afternoon i'll turn it on my screen president gecker superintendent baylow and other distinguished members of the board um and i am dr relly ortiz i'm the director of the office of school quality and with me who will be hitting the buttons today is the associate director

[03:24:53] dr quentin ballard um we were originally planning to bring mou updates that is a requirement by annual mou updates and so that would be happening in november i will be out in november so i thought it was a great time to introduce dr ballard um is there a reason you're going to be out there is a reason that i will be uh it's another reason i'm super hungry i'm like we've been here a while now um and so just wanted um you all to see his face and know that in november he would be bringing the information we've already began compiling the reports um and so november osq will be back in

[03:25:29] front of the board with some additional information great all right and so i will jump right in if it's okay i'm actually honored um to follow two insightful professionals um and while our team is willing to offer items for consideration at the designated time regarding policies identification we truly are the implementation arm of this work and so once the policy has been written ideally with our input in some capacity and schools have been identified the office of school quality begins the process of constructing a personalized support approach obviously in compliance with the

[03:26:08] standards of accreditation and esso which you will hear more about during our time together i have 19 succinct slides for the presentation today and hopefully this context along with context provided by dr schneider and dr hovonitz and the presentation last month by shelley and amy and other members of the team will help you all to expand your conversations regarding accreditation um as you can see on the screen i would like to introduce our team you hear a lot when folks introduce their team they say they're tiny but mighty um and i'll say that definitely about our

[03:26:42] team just a little brief history about who sits in the office of school quality prior to the the pandemic there was a relatively small team 10 to 12 members but they also had a large cadre of consultants they had approximately 200 consultants that had boots on the ground across the commonwealth when i joined the office in 2020 we had an office of approximately 12 staff members that included admin finance so really only about seven or eight of those specialists and coordinators were leading the work with boots on the ground. And some of those

[03:27:18] were a handful of consultants that were in our divisions identified with a memorandum of understatement. Since that time, our office has grown to just under 20 team members, and we built a new team of consultants, that's the picture at the bottom, with a different scope of work and a true focus on building capacity at the division level, which is really one of the core areas of focus for every division that we support. And so looking at the mission of the Office of School Quality to advance learning outcomes by supporting schools and divisions because we have a multi-pronged

[03:27:54] approach. We have direct support of schools and direct support of divisions in the continuous improvement process that obviously complies with state and federal guidelines. And so a little background about our office. Always important to have some context to how our office originated. We We were originally a part of Shelly Loving-Rider's Office of School Improvement, and as you can see, beginning in 2000, the Virginia Board of Education required schools that had not achieved the expected benchmarks to undergo academic reviews, which is still something

[03:28:32] that we do in 2022, and you'll hear more about the academic review process a little later in the presentation. The Office of School Quality was, the Office of School Improvement, which is now the Office school quality was created in 2001 to work closely with low-performing schools to implement best practices and could conduct those academic reviews to analyze a variety of qualitative and quantitative

data and then you'll also see that part of our role is to partner to to create partnerships facilitate those partnerships to provide resources and opportunities for students

[03:29:12] and teachers okay the slide that you're looking at now is an overview of our support model i mean we could be here for a while to talk about the different layers of support but it's an overview and over the years we have been repurposed as a resource for all divisions and schools across the eight division eight regions superintendent regions with an intense focus on designated schools and ensuring compliance with statutes and regulations while we have instituted some

[03:29:48] add-on services which you'll see a little bit later in every area particularly in the universal support there are some compliance pieces that require certain services based on the standards of accreditation and essa and some examples are noted here and that's the school level academic reviews division level academic reviews those division level are part of how divisions are identified for memorandum of understanding which we're going to spend some time on during this presentation continuous school improvement planning how the sig administration is supported

[03:30:23] so school improvement grants we support that in our office instructional leadership professional development initiatives that we have for principals and teachers and then capacity building through coaching which is relatively new in our office in the last year or so and so just to re just to remind the the group the team the board that we are the implementation arm but the standards of accreditation guide our state work and ESSA guides our federal work and so what you're looking at now

[03:31:01] the pyramid visual is a popular one but it gives you a succinct picture of how our office organizes the differentiated supports and interventions much like you see in school for interventions These are the divisions that receive the most intense support.

[03:31:18] Those are the ones that are identified under a memorandum of understanding. Our targeted divisions, as I mentioned, that's a relatively new support system in our office, and that was 12 divisions that had very similar data, very similar indicators to those that were in a memorandum of understanding.

[03:31:41] And so they are our identified or targeted division. then you'll see a universal support model and the universal support model that is more of our tier one it's our webinars it's access to our canvas and so you'll see that they're targeted and differentiated supports and interventions that are based on student performance and local practice okay the next slide is the tiers they offer a little deeper look into the support provided and

[03:32:16] And I know that slide gets a little bit small, but it says, if you are in any one of these models, what is the support that you receive? And that was kind of the ask that I received in coming here today. Share what if they're universal, if they are level identified, level one, identified level two, identified level three.

[03:32:35] There are only three levels and then obviously our divisions within MOU. So what do you do for those schools and what do you do for those divisions? And so you'll see that our divisions within MOU receive the most intense support. So some of those divisions, we have five divisions within MOU currently, they receive sometimes bi-weekly touches.

[03:32:59] So that's every two weeks they're receiving support at some level, whether that's a superintendent or a chief academic officer. There's someone in their LEA that's receiving support from the agency. So we call those off-cycle support meetings.

[03:33:15] We review artifacts. We have the corrective action plan meeting. And so per the memorandum of understanding, we meet every other month with each of those divisions to review artifacts and essential actions. With the exception of one, it's written in their MOU that they can meet quarterly.

[03:33:32] But we meet with them monthly, and they are completely invested in that process as well. And then another thing that is relatively new is that we have partnered with VAS to provide the Virginia Transformational Leaders Academy. So from the Office of School Quality, we worked very closely with principals, division leaders, but then the coaching of superintendents was more of a guide on the side.

[03:33:58] And so we were very intentional over this last year to partner with VAS to provide direct professional learning for the superintendents that sit in divisions with a memorandum of understanding. And some of those superintendents have had years of experience, while others, it may have been their first superintendency.

[03:34:17] And so that intentional support, they have actually appreciated it, even though it's Saturday meetings. They give us feedback on that, and we have a really tight run program there. You'll see the yellow, which, you know, we could identify technically as our tier two.

[03:34:33] Those are divisions that the targeted assistants, again, I mentioned that they look very similar on paper, maybe data-wise, graduation rate, vacancies, student achievement. They look very similar to the divisions under Memorandum of Understanding, but they have not been placed under Memorandum of Understanding.

[03:34:54] And maybe they don't have the same number of indicators, but they were something, once we looked at our data, because, you know, two years of COVID gave us time to really dig into our data, really build out a proactive targeted support model. Just for example, the SOAs say that after three years at a level two, and you all may or may not want to get into the weeds, but I think this is an example that could be useful.

[03:35:21] After three years at level three, the fourth year, they enter into a level two, they enter into a level three. So we would eventually have to support them at a level three status. So we met meeting of the minds and with leadership to say, well, can we be a little proactive before we see them in a more intense space, a level three space, can we offer some support in that area? And so those divisions receive or have support from a consultant as well. And then we have a project lead and our office of coordinator that leads that work, and they stay closely aligned

[03:35:56] with myself and Dr. Ballard for the capacity building divisions. And then you'll see under the universal model, that's where our principal leader comes in. We support all the principals across the Commonwealth. What are best practices? What are some things we want to make sure that we communicate? Leadership development, Canvas. We have a quality quick takes where we get communication out with some helpful information that they can use right away. And then we offer our modules for continuous school improvement we offer that to everyone across the entire commonwealth and so obviously if they're in a targeted situation then they would be expected or

[03:36:33] required to attend those modules and webinars we save seats for them and everything that we do but from the universal standpoint it's more offerings versus requirements are being voluntold and then another thing that's relatively new is the networked improvement community so what we heard not just

from the superintendents with an MOU, but from other divisions across the Commonwealth is we want to talk to our colleagues, our peers and see what's working. And so that is a relatively new,

[03:37:05] the NIC. And so we do work with region five to implement the NIC with some divisions across the across the commonwealth okay so i know this question um well some of the conversation came up in a last month's board meeting and it's divisions within mou and how divisions enter into mou status

[03:37:35] and so as you can see the standards of quality um the standards of accreditation speak to the accreditation of school when we're talking about divisions and how divisions answer i'm sorry standards of accreditation speak to schools if i misspoke the standards of quality speak to how divisions enter into an mou and so we'll leave it there for a moment um i shared with you all that

[03:38:10] they received the most intense um support that's a really small slide yep so we'll go here to the mou process um if you can see the division-led review focuses on the following those are the pieces of each division's MOU. And so each division, even though part of our role is to personalize support, these are the big levers that we use to create strategies. So the academics and student success, leadership and governance, operations and support services, and human

[03:38:49] resource leadership. And so there have been no new schools identified for an MOU since the pandemic. And so prior to the pandemic, a review team went in with representation from various offices within the Virginia Department of Education to do an on-site review. They collect data. They look at where they are in the process as far as if something is full, functional, limited, or no implementation. They interview school board chairperson, vice chairperson, get some of that

[03:39:22] qualitative data. They pull all the data together, look at patterns and trends. And then this agency led by the Office of School Quality in this particular situation will create the report of findings containing essential actions. And that's what's integrated into the corrective action plan. The corrective action plan is what we meet with the division on by monthly. And so we check in with division personnel to see how are you making progress on the particular action items that you have identified or that have been identified by the review of finding, but also they

[03:39:59] also have the ability to contribute some strategies or some things that they know need some assistance or some strategies that have worked. And so that's where we are with the MOU process. And so as you can see here, this provides some historical data of MOUs. Although no new divisions have been identified since the pandemic. We have the most divisions under an MOU since the history

[03:40:35] or conception of MOUs. And so we currently have five divisions in an MOU. Prior to 2020, I would say the average is two divisions in an MOU. So we wanted to provide some additional context so you can see kind of where the resources are going, that intent's targeted. You can see that there are divisions that have been released from the MOU. And then you will see, too, one area of focus that when I mentioned that Virginia Transformational Leaders, what we partnered with

[03:41:11] VAS to do, part of the focus is on division building capacity, communication, alignment, but it's also on succession planning. Because you'll see, for example, a division such as Petersburg that has had six superintendents since the inception of the MOU. And so when we talk about building leadership, we want to make sure that we have a succession planning who can continue the work. And they may leave. We can't chain them there, but they may leave. But at least we know we have designated a person to assist in that area. And that's another reason that we have

[03:41:48] expanded our office's work as well is if we only limit our work to just principals, when the principals and those leaders, those dynamic leaders lead, if the monitoring is not happening at the division level and the follow-up, then we see those schools regress. Same thing with superintendents. You have a dynamic superintendent that comes in, makes some changes, may result in getting out or exiting the MOU. And then when that dynamic, charismatic, the person that pulled the community together leads, then we're sitting back kind of that square one. Okay. So as referenced

[03:42:27] earlier regarding some of the pieces we've expanded, that succession planning, some of the targeted support, there remain items or actions that we're obligated to perform based on the standards of accreditation. And here are two right here. That's academic review and the monitoring process. And so these are required. Some are done independently or with our support upon request.

[03:42:53] We still hold the webinars, newsletter with updates, and monitoring. So with monitoring, we are in the thick of monitoring now. I don't think I sent a shout out to my tiny but mighty team, but they are in the thick of monitoring. And so those 14, 15 specialists and coordinators are meeting with each division to look at their school improvement plan and give them feedback.

[03:43:17] And so it's not just done as a desk audit. Years ago, it was done as a compliance desk audit. you've turned in your school improvement plan it has these components we've checked it off well now they dig deeper into conversations and dialogue what do your interventions look like where do you need support what what resources can we help to provide you and so the monitoring looks different too and that's been a change over the last years and i'll tell you that our 15 to 17 people last year did that for nearly 200 schools and you'll see in the upcoming slide the number of schools that have been identified for the upcoming year that will receive monitoring and academic review

[03:43:56] okay so a little more about the and thank you all for your patience you're on slide 12 and 19 i know you all are writing down some good questions um so more about the academic review process i shared with you all depending on where they are whether they are a level 2 identification or a level 3 identification that determines whether the academic review is done hand in glove with us or whether they can use their tool or the tool that we provide to complete their academic review so we

[03:44:30] gather information alongside the division or the division gathers the information on systems processes and practices related to instructional leadership classroom evaluation climate and culture data analysis assessment and others and then part of the academic review process in an effort to model cyclical processes such as the plan do study act and others we provide a report to findings, we follow up with written and verbal feedback, and then we monitor next steps, and we

[03:45:04] often find ways to customize our technical assistance or link to a resource for professional development. So after we've had that academic review and we've had the monitor, we don't just say good luck with that. We loop back around, we set a date on the calendar for the next meeting, we provide that written feedback and they also um i think dr christy earlier mentioned that in florida everyone gets a point of contact well everyone has a point of contact everyone who undergoes academic review is level one two or three is aware of who their contact is in the

[03:45:41] office of school quality and when we change hands we change introductions and they know who their point person is and so even if they need something from uh food and nutrition or they have a question related to operations in someone else's office. They would start with the Office of School Quality

or a member designated member, and then that member would obviously link them up so they're not chasing all around the agency for support, okay? So school and division responsibilities.

[03:46:08] It builds from what all schools are required to do per the standards of accreditation for level two and level three. And OSQ provides support throughout the process with that focus on the plan do study act and then Virginia's comprehensive school improvement process and that's where I mentioned we hold the modules the webinars we do some of those in person depending on what the division needs or we do some virtually so during COVID we held a lot of virtual now the folks are back in session they want our boots on the ground so our people have been traveling all

[03:46:44] throughout the state from Danville to Nottoway to Buckingham to Greensville to make sure that we can support our schools and divisions. Okay. All right. So this is, I knew we would get here and I knew you all would have questions about this. And so these are the schools that we supported during the pandemic. And this is outside of the divisions that we support within MOU.

[03:47:12] So up until this year, we had been working much like the previous presenter shared. We had been working off school quality indicator performance from the 18-19 school year. And so for, you know, two to three years, we work with those numbers. And so you'll see that the number of schools with level three indicators was right at 192. You can see changes in the number of schools working with our office pre-COVID until now. And so the schools identified with level three indicators based on

[03:47:43] the most recent assessment data would give us 329 schools that we would work with for the upcoming year. And that, remember those statutory pieces, that the monitoring, the academic review. Now, 125 of those 329 schools, and I thought it was important to note, and my team said, don't forget, you have to say this, we're working with science. We're working hand in glove with science. So 125 of those schools are first year level three for science only. And so we are trying to be creative

[03:48:22] and work with them because it is their first year being identified, and we know that science was on the radar. So how do we personalize support? But that is not new. We work all across the agency to work with different offices to make sure we're providing the best support. And so if we were to take that 125 number out, obviously we would be at 200 or so. And with the expansion of our office, we actually are in the hiring process now. We should be able to meet the needs of meeting those folks from a monitoring standpoint and academic review standpoint.

[03:49:00] Okay. And so this was mentioned earlier about our guiding statutory authority. And so the SOQs and the SOAs obviously are state guidelines, but then we also have a group of schools that come to us that have been identified under ESSA. And so just wanted to provide some context for how schools were identified, even though I know that that has been brought to you all last month and then it was brought up in the previous presentation.

[03:49:25] But again, we are the implementation arm. We are the worker bees. So once they are identified and given to us, then we begin that tight working relationship. And then we confer, consult, hold joint webinars, joint technical assistance with other interagency partners to make sure we provide technical assistance to these identified schools.

[03:49:49] And so for this year, Dr. Ballard has put the numbers up for us. Federal has increased by 26 schools, but many overlap because they're also identified in the state funnel or the state net as well. And so we would already be touching those schools from a state support lens.

[03:50:13] Okay. And so one thing that, you know, we always talk about and just earlier, you know, you kept hearing the word transparency, transparency. And so the constant pursuit for our office is related to metrics. It's easy from a compliance point or a compliance lens to say we've delivered over 200 technical assistants, we've monitored 200 schools last year, over 4,000 people subscribed to our letter, we have 1,000 on Canvas, but those are numbers, and measuring our work is an art, it's not a science.

[03:50:46] We take a proactive approach, we do a lot of coaching, but I would say that identifying metrics is not all elusive, but it's definitely more challenging to capture. So we did have schools to exit our care, and so we'd like to believe that our time with them had an impact and take that as a celebration. However, we've also spent time, extra time, in places where the gains aren't as obvious yet in student achievement, but our team has identified intended outcomes and areas of focus and some best practices that we co-construct with those

[03:51:21] divisions and those schools. And so when the team is winning, it's easy to say we've had a hand, But when they continue to struggle, then what? And so we look at our approach, our systems and processes, and where one division is in one space, another one is in a completely different space.

[03:51:38] For example, when we were working with our divisions under a memorandum of understanding, one particular division had not provided administrator performance evaluation in two to three years. And so we dig in and we start there.

[03:51:54] You know, how are we monitoring these principles? Like we need to hold folks accountable. And that's not a bad thing. Accountability is not bad in that way, but that's where we start. But then if we have another division that is really struggling with the written, taught, and tested curriculum, that's where we start with that particular division.

[03:52:10] So they really all don't start at the same place, and they all don't finish at the same place. And it's what we do in a classroom. We try to capitalize on strengths and cover their blind spots. And so just in closing, and then obviously we're here for questions, education systems are not and this quote is powerful and we use it with our consultants it's not simply collections of independently effective parts and pieces effective systems by definition are parts and pieces that work in harmony with one another each one reinforcing and supporting all the functioning of the other parts and pieces and all of them together contributing to the system's high performance

[03:52:49] and so i we are i am here for questions i won't put dr ballard out just yet he'll be here next month um but ready for any questions that you you all may have for us yeah um what is the frequency of the school level and division level academic reviews like what's the the reviews that happen you mentioned in the services services provided by the osq you mentioned um

[03:53:25] school level and division level academic reviews what's the frequency of these so the academic reviews are only done yearly but the monitoring is done more frequently and so the academic review is more intense um that's where we go in and we collect that qualitative and quantitative data um and the team may do some walkthroughs they may not they may have already sometimes they give feedback on the feedback so if the principals and central office staff have already gone in and given feedback then we may take a look at that in addition to obviously student achievement data but the academic reviews are once per year but monitoring we get in more

[03:54:03] frequently so this is school level or division level they're both annual for the academic review okay and um are reviews for like governor's schools any different and so they would likely not be identified based on their student achievement data and so the schools that qualify for academic review would be our level three schools and then some level two schools okay i i thought this was

[03:54:35] uh osq knows for every every school but it's supporting so we ideally could support every school and we do from the universal approach and so from the universal approach we provide like a webinar like we could say hey we're going to talk about the school improvement plan um and so this webinar is open to anyone across the commonwealth who would like to okay i think i might have misinterpreted it okay thanks but the intent services are reserved for level two

[03:55:08] the mous um the academics and student success would you what kind of data points do you do you collect for the student success to to yeah if you can clarify that and so the the data that we collect is based on their essential action so the their student achievement data would have to be such that they've already been identified and given to our office because we don't do the

[03:55:42] identification so whatever data student achievement whether it's reading all or particular reporting groups that would all be done through the identification arm of our agency when they're handed to us then the essential actions are created and so an essential action may be specific to moving certain student achievement in certain areas and that's what we will monitor whatever was identified in the corrective action plan as one of their action steps or essential action items. Was there a significance in the keeping the the numbers of superintendents since

[03:56:18] approval of MOU there? Is there a significance of that number? I mean do you track it like I saw it in your chart in your table? And I think it's important to note because as leadership changes sometimes there are changes at the division at the school level um and so when there is and and we've seen this in other divisions when there is support and uh monitoring at the division level then schools usually can maintain and there is some research that probably could point to um they can maintain uh accreditation because the support systems and the resources are there when the

[03:56:56] division superintendent changes there may be another vision um there may be less monitoring there may be different monitoring and so sometimes we don't see the same sustainability when there are changes and then obviously the superintendent has to build relationships with the school board and sometimes that dynamics you know plays a part in how things you know move in the division so um just a couple more questions so for the academic reviews you mentioned um things like you know webinars and school improvement plans or audits for interventions and so i'm just

[03:57:32] wondering on the, at the, in the, at the school level for the students affected, how, what does it look like? Are they offered tutoring, like extra tutoring, incentivized tutoring, or even maybe make it mandatory for extra work or to help them get on, you know, get up to speed in the various subjects? Is that? So we do talk about that. And again, part of our role is to help the division with the resources they have or complement resources. And so there are divisions

[03:58:08] that have individualized tutoring and they work with vendors or partners to do that. If they were to say to the Office of School Quality, we really want to, and this was something that, you know, actually happened over the last few years, we want to offer some extended day. And so we want to use some of our funds to transport students home if we can keep them here. That would be an area that we could support. Or if they say, well, we want to have an extended school year, so we're going to add five days

on to each part of the calendar. That approval doesn't live in our office, but we make sure they go to the right person in the agency. And if we can support in

[03:58:45] any way with some instructional resources or some funding, then we would help to provide that support. And so, yes, we help them as long as it's in their essential actions. They're trying to move student achievement. Then we may partner them with someone in the agency. We may provide some financial support or you know we may just serve as as a bridge in some capacity thank you andy this is great thank you um i said one question and and it's it i think it could be illustrative what's up like what's our role if things are going sideways and so for example i'm watching richmond right now and just from what i see like in the newspaper and so forth like it

[03:59:23] seems like they've got a pretty good reading curriculum for instance but the board has now decided like maybe to overhaul curriculum and so forth like if they move to something that's not as as quality of a curriculum in terms of being like you know aligned with science and reading and so forth like what's our role what's our appropriate role as the board in a situation like that and so um from my seat i would say that the standards of quality are in place for a reason and so that's just not an office of school quality thing like we're a resource we're implementation but the standards of quality say or the standards accreditation say your curriculum should be

[04:00:02] aligned like we have the you know standards of accreditation for a reason so they should not step too far from that now if they have you know sometimes they use additional resources or strategies to get to the end goal and so that's where you know we would continue to support because we do review any new instructional programs so that is part of language that is written in the mou instructional programs but the curriculum itself should meet the standards that every other school is responsible for every other division is responsible for in the state and if it doesn't though is there an enforcement mechanism or are we more in like a supportive role through

[04:00:41] these mous so from the office of school quality yes we are more supportive but as far as if they were not to follow it then there are some um punitive measures of sorts and that would be related to holding back funding and things like that but obviously before i would consider anything like that, I would want, you know, Superintendent Baylo to weigh in, President Decker to weigh in, the board to weigh in, you know, because that's taking money from a division that needs to support students. So, you know, we really try to work from that coaching capacity. And that's why

[04:01:17] I've probably spent more time in the last, you know, few months or years working with board chairs. Before our work has been limited or, you know, we have the ability to, but really working with superintendents but now seeing that dynamics we really want to work to facilitate and serve as a bridge so that they can have healthy relationships and partnerships for their community but at the end of the day the soqs are in place for a reason the soas are in place and we're going to keep driving them back to that with our you know resource push or even with our coaching push thank you absolutely and yeah can i just add to that just for a second yes you know

[04:01:55] our role as a board under the memoranda you know differs slightly depending which one you're using right so uh but predominantly the memorandum for richmond for example gives responsibilities to the department for oversight the board's role in oversight is actually fairly minimal they are required to meet with jillian and me twice a year but osi gets to review in theory all purchases well not all but everything dealing with instructional materials there's a list of

[04:02:30] things that in theory come before osi for approval uh you know one of the problems is that there's not a great enforcement mechanism that's pointed out when they just go and do things and don't run through uh staff um so the memoranda are i mean they're there but the teeth aren't really there to do much and you know it's that the conflict in virginia over who's got control over the local schools right it plays out here too and you know for better or for worse you know the locals tend

[04:03:07] to win the conflict battle always no matter what's going on inside the division so although you know as dr ortiz mentioned there is some ability potentially more than potentially there's some statutory language which would allow funding to be taken and i know you know under the previous superintendent there had been some discussion about actually doing that the problem with that is it hurts the wrong people and so it's a measure that you know we have not been willing to take to date yeah i mean that is a pretty extreme measure but there's nothing in between on like just having

[04:03:46] we don't have oversight over decisions like that even if they're decisions that are contra the mou without having to go to extreme like that we just there's just not well the department doesn't have a lot of leverage i would say a little differently in that you know the mous are well this one richmond specifically was sort of negotiated at the podium and there was a lack of um or that there was a desire to accommodate certain things that the city school division wanted in the memorandum

[04:04:23] them that weakened it just a little bit, right? They wanted more control retained, and they got that through this memorandum. It's not clear to me if they were to come before us today, we would adopt the same document. You know, the Petersburg memorandum has changed over time. You know, it still doesn't have a lot of teeth to it, but on the other hand, there were provisions added back in whatever, 16 or 17, I don't remember which, so don't hold me to the date. That strengthened it a little bit. But that was also combined with state funding to allow them to hire a superintendent

[04:05:02] with a much higher salary, division superintendent with a much higher salary than they would have been able to do otherwise. Predominantly, my experience with this has been, and it's not near as great as Dr. Ortiz, so feel free to correct me at all. But from the outside perspective, looking in and going to the meetings you know the first look well you have the corrective action plan right which they're expected to follow through second is we preach a lot about the necessity of good board governance we preach a lot about how to build up a central office

[04:05:40] right to administer and then we preach a lot about curriculum alignment and dr ortiz really feel free to you know fill in but this is my synthesis of six years or five years of meetings with school board chairs and superintendents along with OSI or OSQ and you know sometimes you can feel it working and sometimes you realize that it's not going to work I mean if you look at and I mean somebody's going to slap me for saying this but if you look at the governance situation

[04:06:14] in Richmond as an example where you've got a predominance of five four votes uh you know clear conflict with the superintendent the lack of you know the superintendent's leadership team having left. It's difficult for anybody from the outside to come in and say, here's what you've got to do because the board's just, you know, the division itself hasn't been able to figure out which direction. Contrast that with, you know, Petersburg, which seven, eight years ago, you know, may have been, and I've talked to Mr. Pritchard about this, who was the chair, they may have been the worst

[04:06:49] board ever, which is an exaggeration, but they have converted themselves into a board that is 100% behind the educational mission of the schools. I mean, they are no longer in any sense an

impediment to progress in Petersburg. You have other issues, but the board is no longer one of them. And so, you know, Petersburg's been under MOU for 18 years. And one of the things, you know, I'd like from Dr. Ortiz, if you don't mind answering a question since I've talked so much about this, is, you know, it's frustrating for me six years later to be sitting here saying we still

[04:07:28] have these issues, right? And there's not much I see we can do. It's got to hit you, you know, folks, well, I know you've been here before, but folks who haven't seen this before, as why can't we do more? And so, Dr. Ortiz, if we could wave the magic wand, what powers would we like to have to be able to make change in the divisions? That's a great question. If I can bottle it and sell it, I don't think I'd be sitting right here. But I'll say that even, you know, Ms. Holton brought up a point about vacancies, attracting the best to some of those

[04:08:07] divisions, and then sustainability, longevity. And so when, you know, you have neighboring divisions that are paying something very similar, a lot of your stellar teachers, leaders, they don't stay long. It's challenging work in a challenging division. And so, you know, that's part of it. And I wouldn't say that's the only part of it, but that's a large part of it as well. Targeted professional learning. We really work to coach division leaders on what does that look like before there were the blanket PDs. How do you personalize that for what they need?

[04:08:45] So there are so many different pieces, President Gecker, that can go into it. And as I shared earlier, everybody is at a different place. Every division is at a different starting line. So they're going to have a different finish line, but they have to have some coherence. They have to have to be in the fight together. So whatever that end vision is, the more that they can work together on that and that we can help them, then we want to do that. But I'll tell you, there is no magic. You know, yes, the curriculum is there. Dr. Baller pulled it up and it's the law. They're required to follow certain guidelines. That's not an OSQ thing. And so if we see those things,

[04:09:21] then we obviously want to address them. But we also want to build capacity at that level because they, you know, even if we're there once a week, what about, you know, they have four days. If we're there one day a week, what about the four other days? So they have to have capacity at that level.

[04:09:37] And Richmond is one of the few divisions, you know, when we look at all five-car divisions within MOU, that is still struggling to fulfill central office positions. And so, you know, when you don't have a lead, right, you have a lead superintendent who's trying to manage all the other fires that going on um you know our danville our petersburg their central offices are stacked and so we can at least work with them and coach them versus having vacancies in positions that is definitely more challenging to build capacity in that space yeah grace so that capacity building is something

[04:10:12] that that i would really like to pull some more data out of um so for the places like richmond Petersburg, those divisions that have had repeated scenarios under MOUs, I'd really like to look at specifically what are our building principals feeling on a daily basis? Because at the end of the day, we can help support superintendents all day long, but if it's not flowing downhill, our outcomes aren't going to change, right? So what I would really like to know in those MOU

[04:10:50] divisions is from their building principles perspective, like true transparency, 100% honesty, what time are they spending in some really significant pieces of their job? Like if I'm looking at it, I want an MOU divisions building principle to be the instructional leader in that school. But the practical

implementation of that, as we all know in this room, is very different, right? And so I would love to know the percentage of time that each one of those

[04:11:27] building principals spends in instructional leadership, mentoring teachers. So that's kind of like one thing, instructional leadership slash mentoring teachers. The second is student discipline. And the third is kind of like other human resources type issues that are not related in any sense to either of the first two. Because I think truly that can inform other interventions

[04:11:56] that we may need to address in this particular scenario. Do we need to provide an instructional support mechanism in all five of those days instead of just one of those four? What is it that we can truly change to help these divisions get to where we all want them to be from now into the long, long, long future to really change the outcomes for generations that have been

[04:12:30] strapped in these kinds of situations that we're seeing repeatedly. That is something I know that we all want to achieve. And so what are some of those things that we can pinpoint and make like pretty quick changes on.

[04:12:47] Can we help teachers instructionally in the classroom in a more significant way, you know, than a school, a building principal has or a building assistant principal has in the time that they're there with those kids and those teachers every day. So what can we do to support that is really something that I'd really like for us to explore a little more.

[04:13:09] - And I will tell you all good points and definitely would require some deep digging. Some of our work that we do at the division when we're having those corrective action plan meetings is we talk about like the number of walkthroughs. So we may not talk about like the time spent, but we say how many walkthroughs have each of your principals done?

[04:13:28] Actually, if you are a principal director, how many times have you been in the building to monitor what they are doing? And then part of our work with the monitoring, when I said we got away kind of from the desk audits, and so we still obviously check their school improvement plan and look at their paperwork, but we also have conversations And we do that with the principal present.

[04:13:48] And there have been discoveries where the principal goes, I would really like to do more of this and focus on instruction. But central office has me doing this or they pull me out of the building for this one. I really could be doing this. And so we'll try to, again, serve as a bridge and a resource. Hey, central office, you hear what your principals are saying. It's not meant to be used as anything punitive.

[04:14:05] And so that's why we've gone to some of those division level conversations where we have the principals in the space, but we also have a division leader in the space that we can make some of those connections. But all the points and all would change the trajectory of students' lives if we can get that deep and hold them accountable for that, for sure.

[04:14:24] - Anybody else? Ms. Holkin. - Thank you, and thank you, Dr. Ortiz. A comment and a question. Comment is, I bet that we have vacancies and turnover issues with principals as well as with teachers and superintendents.

[04:14:41] And I posit that the real solution to that has gotta be money. and money is not something you have capacity to give these troubled schools. You know, it's governed by the funding formula. You may be able to have them tinker with a grant here or there.

[04:14:58] You may be able to direct some small funds, but I think I'm right unless something's majorly different. You can't allocate more resources to them to enable them to attract and retain more experienced, more effective teachers, principals, and to hold onto their superintendents for a few years.

[04:15:14] Gosh forbid. My question is actually also related to money. Your office's capacity, I see from the numbers you've shared with us today and also looking at the accreditation numbers, the number of accreditation, the number of schools accredited with conditions went up 50% this year, went up from something like 129 to 190 something, a 50% increase.

[04:15:38] And the number of these numbers you've given us showed increases of 60, 70% in schools with level two or three indicators and therefore on your workload going up 60 to 70% or more.

[04:15:55] Remember that the introduced budget for 2022 included a very significant, I think I recall correctly, a significant increase for your office's budget. Did you get any of that?

[04:16:10] What was the outcome? Has your budget gone up since from last year to this year? And if not, the state budget, Have you gotten significant federal relief funds or, you know, what, how are you expanding? How are you responding to that increased capacity or what you need to be able to respond to the increased capacity?

[04:16:30] And so whether it was general assembly or leadership, we have the money to hire more positions. Just like schools, we are struggling to fill some of the positions that we have as well. And so, you know, it takes a very special, special person not only to work at the agency, but to work with the most challenged schools.

[04:16:49] And so right now, I mentioned earlier, we're in a hiring spree of sorts. We have up to seven more positions that we can fill in the office. And so if we look at those seven positions that are waiting to be filled, we would split those schools among the new staff that come on.

[04:17:08] And so for now, we make sure that, you know, obviously we meet the statutory requirements, the compliance pieces, the monitoring, the academic reviews. But we've also been able to open up lanes that OSQ historically has not done with that proactive targeted support. Now, we knew the numbers would go up.

[04:17:25] Maybe science shot us just a little bit more. Maybe it was just me. Maybe it wasn't other people in my office. Maybe it was just me. So we really have revamped our plan and worked tightly with that department to get that done. But I'll tell you, we always work to get better at getting better. and extra hands can only help many hands make light work um so we definitely can take more but with the people we have where you know i'll use the word managing but again impact is negligible right and so we have schools that have exited we have schools that have entered and so we want to make sure we are consistent in our processes and they know what to expect from the office of school

[04:17:58] quality and just as a follow-up i think i remember seeing data from you or your predecessor comparing our office of school quality to some of our neighbors and i don't remember if it was north carolina or where but you're half capacity compared to them relative to the number of schools you're serving do you know anything about how we compare to other states who have a how big is your office compared to the need compared to other states some of that ms holton i think was maybe from the jlark report and then our follow-up where we had a huge budget ask um to grow our office

[04:18:35] And so at that time, we were, and I would have to get you the exact numbers of where we are now because I didn't have my data person. That's a new role, data coordinator. We put that in place, instituted that this year. We were at a 1 to 22 caseload, approximately 1 to 22 specialists and then the number of schools that they support.

[04:18:56] And then there was some comparison, obviously, to North Carolina, to Tennessee that, you know, we're at a 1 to 3 ratio or something along those lines. But again, they had different funding formulas. There's all sorts of things that go into there. I found out later that, you know, Georgia, they pay for different add-on services. So the division is responsible fiscally for paying if they wanted some additional services where we just, you know, offer these things. And so I don't know with the new hires, I would have to give you the exact numbers of where we are now.

[04:19:24] Yeah, I'd be interested in that. And in particular, I think you're right. What I'm remembering is that the JLARC recommendation was that you needed a significant increase. How much of that have you got? And I hear that you haven't even able to, you don't have in practice what you have on paper because you can't fill the positions. But are you authorized for the positions you need or do we need to be pushing for more authorization over the longer haul?

[04:19:48] Thank you both for being with us. I think we're going to push on to the next, since we are running a tiny bit later than we expected. I'll tell you, Dr. Ortiz, how much I appreciate the work you've done and what I've seen.

[04:20:06] I've been in a lot of meetings with you, and it always gives me comfort that somebody knows what they're doing when I listen to you talk to the divisions. Thank you. So thank you very much for your work. I accept that. Thank you. I'll look at the information Ms. Holt that you asked for and OSP we'll see you all next month.

[04:20:25] Thanks y'all. - Thanks for that to you. - That's right. We've got one new hire coming, huh? - Yes. - Thanks Dr. Baloch. - Yeah, thank you. All right, update on the process and stakeholder work group for House Bill 938.

[04:20:45] Ms. Webb, Dr. Sale. - Good afternoon, President Gecker, Superintendent Baylow and members of the board. We are delighted to be before you today to provide an update on House Bill 938.

[04:21:02] And can we get our slides up? There we go. We're looking for the clicker. So with me today is Dr. Sale, who you all are very familiar with, as well as Kathleen Dempsey.

[04:21:20] I am delighted to introduce you all to Kathleen. She is with us via Zoom. She has joined our team as the House Bill 938 Project Coordinator. All of this work would certainly not be possible without her leadership in coordination.

[04:21:36] And I'll do a brief introduction of her before I turn over those slides to her. Kathleen has worked in Virginia Beach City Public Schools and also has served as the director of the North Central Comprehensive Center, providing technical education assistance to Nebraska, North Dakota, South Dakota, and Wyoming.

[04:21:56] And she joined us back in August and has hit the ground running ever since. As we talk to you all in August, this presentation or this report does have a fairly quick timeline of November 30th of this year.

[04:22:14] And we will be bringing a draft to you all in November, but we just wanted to provide an update in advance of that report coming. So, Kathleen, I will turn it over to you. Well, thank you, Emily. And it's great to be with you and the board and Superintendent Baylow today.

[04:22:33] We're going to discuss the activities of the workgroup and the tasks that they've been able to complete and the tasks that are still remaining. We're going to start with those topics that were in HC 938.

[04:22:51] And, you know, one of the first tasks was to do some organization. as we look at those topics um there are three of the six that are very discreet and so those remain as specific discussion topics but there were three also in that group that were interconnected and so there was the perception that a change in one would likely result in a needed change in another and so one of the first tasks that was completed was to group these discussion topics

[04:23:30] and so you'll see on that slide that we have more discussion topics there we have been discussing the mathematics achievement instruction certainly the information about the advanced studies diploma the promoting data transparency and meaningful school accreditation that's where those three topics were combined and then certainly the maintaining standards of learning proficiency

[04:24:02] standards that's a discussion group that's really focused on how cut scores are arrived and for the various proficiency levels within reading and mathematics a part of the work that had to be done early on was to get some external resources and i was a part of getting a new resource as far as being the project consultant and then we also reached out to region 5 comprehensive center

[04:24:37] they are there to support the department and initiatives within the stake and so they've been helping with meeting organizations and also with facilitation so those were some of the early tasks that were completed once we had those things in place we could start with setting up our meeting and so we were able to schedule four meetings we have conducted meeting one and meeting two and we'll discuss those a little bit more in just a minute meeting three will actually

[04:25:13] be held this week so we're we're close to having that discussion and we do show meeting four if needed and i anticipate that we're going to use that meeting time if we may need to finalize some of the recommendations or it may be a time that work group members are providing feedback on on the draft report um so our meetings are in place and being conducted a part of this was also

[04:25:47] identifying our work group members and that did take some time and some work you'll see from the slide that we've got parents and teachers and principals and superintendents and members from school boards and institutions of higher learning, as well as business and industry. And certainly they're from the eight different regions across Virginia. So they've been an engaged group, ready to discuss, ready to respond when I connect with them through email.

[04:26:25] And so they've been a great group to work with. So once we had our meetings and our group, we were ready to start with our meeting number one. And meeting number one was held September 23rd.

[04:26:46] And, you know, each of our meetings had a specific purpose and certainly identified outcomes that we wanted to achieve. And for meeting number one, it was to make sure that our workgroup members understood the task and that they really understood what these six topics were about.

[04:27:08] So prior to meeting number one, our department, the VDOE subject matter specialist, compiled really a significant amount of information.

[04:27:24] And this information, we zipped it together in a zip folder and sent it to our work group members so that they would have it prior to meeting time. They were able to review it beforehand, and then certainly to reference it during the meeting.

[04:27:44] And during that meeting, we discussed the task and the organization. It was great to have Superintendent Bailo with us to welcome the workgroup members. And then during that time, subject matter specialists from the department conducted briefings in each of those four areas.

[04:28:06] Workgroup members were able to reference those files that had been sent, and then this was a time of a lot of questions that came from workgroup members. We couldn't address every question during the meeting time, but we were able to, all of those questions were recorded and then distributed to the correct people to get responses.

[04:28:34] And we compiled both those questions and responses and sent it to our workgroup members prior to meeting number two. The other thing that we did in meeting number one was to find out about the interests of our workgroup members.

[04:28:53] You know, we realized, given our timeline, that not every member would be able to dig deeply during meeting time into every topic. And so we asked them for their areas of interest where they would most like to focus their meeting time.

[04:29:14] And they gave us their top two choices. And then we used those choices when we were putting together the breakout group for meeting two. So meeting number one, I would say, really set the stage and provided the resources for what our workgroup members needed to then provide input for us.

[04:29:39] So after meeting number one, we had meeting number two, and that was just one week after. So it was, you know, a quick turnaround, certainly for all of us, but actually that worked out quite well.

[04:29:58] We broke into breakout groups for most of the time, and each breakout group had work group members and facilitators and the subject matter specialists, note takers.

[04:30:14] You know, the breakout groups were recorded and we set it up much like a focus group. So we used prompts to engage the discussion of work group members and then to gather their input.

[04:30:32] We had a couple of rounds, actually, of these breakout sessions to give members an opportunity to participate in more than one discussion group. And then we all came back together in whole group.

[04:30:51] And the key points from their discussions were shared as a whole group. And then we had a little time for discussion there. After that meeting, we compiled all the comments from these breakout groups and the key discussion points.

[04:31:09] And we've shared that back with our stakeholders. And then that is something that they, again, are using to prepare for meeting three, which will be this Friday. And it was also during the second meeting that we started to hear some emerging themes.

[04:31:31] So these are definitely not-- they're not recommendations. But they are themes that are coming from the discussion. And I think that top bullet point is something that we've heard over and over, in all honesty, from every discussion group about communication being critical.

[04:32:00] You know, the discussion is around better articulation of the policies and the processes, how things get done at the state level, and then, of course, at the division and the school level so that this discussion can be held with community members.

[04:32:27] There's been a lot of discussion about the audience receiving information and how to make that information digestible. So that's been a discussion point.

[04:32:43] Certainly, that discussion about additional stakeholders, and that's positively received about including more stakeholders and processes. It was interesting. There was a caveat about always making sure these other stakeholders were prepared or trained or ready to participate, whether it's with information or actual training modules.

[04:33:12] So we'll hear more about what they think on some of these points, certainly on Friday. That focus on post-secondary and career preparation, we certainly heard that in the advanced studies diploma discussion, but in other discussion areas as well.

[04:33:35] The importance of CTE and the opportunities that that provides students was a part of that discussion. So that's certainly been interesting. The growth discussion in accreditation was certainly interesting.

[04:33:55] And there was that-- the discussion really was about the need to keep growth in some way as a part of that accreditation model. I'm sure we'll hear more, too, again, about that on Friday.

[04:34:11] You see that next bullet about more clear communication. And again, that was discussed quite a bit. And I thought that last bullet there about thoughtful pacing and mathematics, there was some discussion about access from elementary to middle and high, and how at the elementary level, at times, It seems the content area is a little more accessible, and then it becomes more quickly paced and challenging as they move up to middle and high school.

[04:34:49] You know, I'm not really sure where that discussion is going to lead, but that was a part of the discussion with the breakout group. So that's kind of what we've been doing, and we do still have a few more.

[04:35:07] things to do. We're gathering individual input, actually, at this point. This morning, as a matter of fact, one of my tasks was to pull together input that we received from our stakeholders.

[04:35:23] You know, we recognized that stakeholders had not had the opportunity to participate in deep discussions on every topic. So we wanted to make sure if they had any more input to provide or recommendations to offer, that they had a clear opportunity to do that. And so we've been compiling. We did receive some, not all, but there were a few that provided us with some extra input and some recommendations.

[04:36:01] And so I'm compiling that, and we'll send it back out to them before our Friday meeting. We've got to conduct meeting number three. And during that meeting, we're going to focus on identifying recommendations and then also being able to prioritize those recommendations.

[04:36:21] We are working on the report, and as each task is completed or accomplished, then we add to the report along the way. We'll conduct meeting number four, and then we'll have that draft report ready for you next month.

[04:36:43] So, you know, there have been a lot accomplished, I would think, but still there is work to be done. and I guess we're ready for questions and discussion. - Great, are there any questions? Thank you for the work you've done on this.

[04:37:03] Dada. - I have some questions. Thank you for the presentation. - Yeah, thanks. - So a couple of comments. One of them is that the bill, HB 938, you know, notes other concerns, stakeholders, and I'm glad you had a point there in your presentation about that because I was thinking, you know, I've been wondering that for a bill this magnitude and importance which has a chance of making a positive difference in our public schools we should be thinking outside the box and to prevent an echo chamber we should get

[04:37:42] participation from you know external entities such as for example private school educators to get fresh ideas different perspective and diversity of thought and i know that the presentation is you know noted it's a time very tight deadline um and i'm hoping that you're able to engage more people because it's need to think outside the box um second point is that um we had a presentation today by dr christy hoven it's on a transparent and meaningful accreditation system and i so i

[04:38:21] hope that in the future we're able to move virginia towards that kind of clear-cut accreditation Other than that, I think this sounds great, and thank you for all the work you're doing.

[04:38:38] Thank you. Ms. Dutta, I'm happy to talk a little bit about kind of stakeholders. Obviously, we've all mentioned the short timeline that we have here. We did work with Superintendent Baylow to identify those stakeholders, certainly got recommendations from several of you to serve on the group.

[04:38:56] I will note we did want to keep it relatively manageable. We could have had hundreds of people serve on the stakeholder group, but we also wanted to be sure to meet the deadline that the General Assembly has given us. Certainly I think that there's going to be areas of engagement even after the report.

[04:39:18] Accreditation is a big piece of that, and the board is currently starting the discussions about it. So we certainly think we'll be able to engage more stakeholders in the long run as the board and the General Assembly start to consider the recommendations that the work group may put forward and then look towards implementing those that they want to carry forward. So it is a challenge to figure out how to do a broad swath of stakeholder engagement, but we're certainly trying our best and look forward to hopefully creating other opportunities in the future as well. Great. I'm just going to skip to the end if I may. And to go, this timeline and this cut

[04:39:57] time to get this report back what is going to be our board's opportunity to kind of weigh in on it because you know we have benefited from conversations the last couple months about accreditation excellent presentations today like i pointed out so um i could just are we going to have another chance for input or is this going to just apply back to general something i think dr siebert that's a that's a really good question um certainly we are working to prepare the report as quickly as possible um and we'll work with superintendent baylow and secretary gadara on

[04:40:31] it as well um so i think you know we're certainly open to to feedback from the board but again i hate to go back to the timeline it is you know fairly tight um for us what is indicators you know basically like you know our conversation about if you want to be comfortable yeah there's just a big conference here, but okay. Sure. And, you know, I also think that this report is going to help inform some of what the

board does next. You know, you all can utilize this report, you know, as a, I think a starting point, certainly not as the end point around where you necessarily want to

[04:41:09] go. Yeah. So we'll see the report before it goes, but again, remembering the legislation, our role in this was to collaborate with the superintendent and the secretary to bring a group of stakeholders together. The report actually under the statute doesn't come from us. It comes from the secretary and the superintendent. So as Emily just said, maybe this informs our work and we may have separate asks about separation of accountability and accreditation later on. But at the end of the

[04:41:39] day, this one is not our report. This belongs to a different group. Anybody else? I don't see anybody. So thank you all very much. And Emily, I guess you stay sitting, right? I do. Yes, sir.

[04:41:58] yeah thank you ms dempsey we appreciate it you're welcome go ahead um i'm just going to open up this uh section on the agenda really quickly and first of all thank emily for all of it over to you okay oh great um and and first of all just um just acknowledge the incredible amount of work in a

[04:42:29] short amount of time that emily has has completed um you know she in this report is is not only asked to do what the statute says but also asked to encapsulate what would would be seen by all of us as an unprecedented change in in the membership of the board that took place in july and typically this annual report would include things like priorities information about the state of schools information about legislation recommendations and asks by the board but because there was a change

[04:43:06] in july and because this board has not really reset priorities in a formal way that was really really difficult to encapsulate so i'm going to encourage this entire board to really engage in a discussion and recognize that the reason that this is coming to you almost two months before it's due maybe over two months before it's due okay month and a half before it's due one meeting okay is because um we we really really need to hear your substantive edits your substantive ideas and um not only to inform this report but really to inform our work going forward as a board

[04:43:46] and um so just uh again thanks to emily for working with lots of folks across the agency but this is a not even a drafty draft this is a drafty drafty draft thank you would you just take a step back and what exactly is the purpose of this report and the board is obligated under the constitution of the commonwealth to give an annual report to the legislature and the governor as to the state of virginia schools that's what this that's the baseline for what this is uh

[04:44:19] typically uh well the report contains as you can see a lot of appendices that have a lot of data that's not controversial in that it is what it is uh the board has also in years past and it predates my tenure on the board and i'm assuming andy when you were on last time you did this also the board listed its priorities uh set out its work plan etc yeah i will say i disagree just a little bit and i don't care if we include those things or not but at some point i think we have to stop referring to the board as sort of the old and the new and recognize the continuity of the

[04:44:56] institution and just say we're the board, right? I mean, I take responsibility or credit or, you know, blame for anything Andy's last board did. I mean, we are a continual institution, and I don't think it's helpful long term for us. At some point, we just have to recognize the institution moves on.

[04:45:18] That being said, you know, what we include, this is not a department report. This is a board report. and you know in years past the department has not had much editing to this it has been strictly the board i understand this year is different and that's fine as a way to start the process but where we are is we

will submit because you know we like to be timely on things the annual report by year end which means we hopefully will adopt one at the november meeting

[04:45:52] so the point of today is to give emily in particular as sort of the custodian of the draft feedback on what's here uh and you know it may not hurt and you know unfortunately you know the document didn't come out until you know yesterday yeah and so many pages well exactly no i mean in years past we've been a little bit earlier and uh you know this year we were the day before this meeting which is unfortunate but it might pay to go back and read last year's report for example

[04:46:29] and prior year's report no i'm not laying the blame on you emily i understand internal stuff the uh the point is that uh the board gets to decide as a board what the document looks like there is no prescribed form and you know as chair of the board i'm comfortable with whatever the board decides the form looks like you know we just need to make a decision about what gets included like i said in the old days and you know in the past you know the boards the board of ed as an entity had not prescribed standards of quality for give or take 20 years that was an

[04:47:06] important thing that got highlighted in the last few reports because it spoke to policy jillian's point is that you know that policy may no longer be the policy of this board although by our bylaws is the policy until the board changes it but that doesn't mean we have to highlight that within this document right two separate concepts there i mean right now the policy of the board is the prescribed soqs it doesn't mean they have to be in the document as an example right this is our it's free form uh there is no prescribed uh format for this although i think keeping the charts

[04:47:42] for the benefit of the legislators in relatively the same form i'll make this editorial comment is a good idea because they'll look back year over year and if we make major changes in the format of the charts and reports i think that would be problematic so for soq you're talking about i'm just looking in when you say that traditionally they they've included the soqs in here and that includes what the we we have included the major changes that the board that is in 2019 adopted or

[04:48:20] prescribed to the and re-prescribed year over year the major changes there were inclusion of funds i mean what we essentially said as a board back in 19 was if we're going to make differences in outcomes we're going to have to change the allocation of teachers this is one thing because if you look typically poorer schools have less effective teachers teaching there meaning more inexperienced teachers and this is not inconsistent with what we heard today right there is a resource difference in the effectiveness of the teachers and so what the board proposed

[04:48:58] through the soqs was the provision of funds which would allow actually mandate uh local you know poor local jurisdictions to either hire more experienced teachers because virginia unlike florida does not have a measure of effectiveness that's based upon growth right so we used experience as a proxy for effectiveness or reduce class size and have more inexperienced teachers where we're looking for ways to cut the achievement gap second and again pre-pandemic and i know post-pandemic things are worse we are very we're very concerned about the teacher shortage

[04:49:36] the inability to attract teachers to the profession teachers not staying in the profession and so we He believed, based upon the information we gathered over time, that one of the ways to stem that tide was one of the reasons teachers, young teachers, leave the profession early.

[04:49:54] A significant reason is lack of support, lack of training, right? And we propose that we implement a significant mentorship program around those teachers. And again, I'm not putting this out to agree or disagree with. It's just sort of the underlying policies.

[04:50:11] was uh bring back the reading specialists okay so i see these 11 exactly now you see what i'm talking about and so the i see these money there's money associated with each of those and who comes up with this well under the constitution of the commonwealth the general assembly is actually responsible for dividing the cost of education between the state and the locals and the the standards of quality are not only sort of a basic uh you know ratio of you know teachers to students

[04:50:44] and principals and psychologists etc it's also essentially a funding mechanism right because and it also allows you to decide how much the system will you know will cost so essentially the assembly adds up what the soqs the minimum staffing standards would require cost wise and And then they say the state's going to take X dollars of that, and the locals have to pay Y dollars of that.

[04:51:12] And that's how funding gets done. I mean, that's a very, very short-form explanation. There are then modifiers based upon what they call the Local Composite Index, and then there's a million different, you know, tinkerings around the edges of it. But by and large, the base document, and Andy, I know you're an expert on this, so you disagree with this explanation when I get it wrong.

[04:51:34] I'm not an expert on it. Doing okay so far? I mean, essentially, the SOQs, you know, which they did not adopt, would, at least the board's SOQs, the board's SOQs and the state's SOQs both would sort of set out the minimum dollars required under the Constitution to be allocated to public education, K-12.

[04:52:00] The state decided to, actually they allocated a lot of dollars, but they did not allocate them in accordance with the standards of quality we put out. They kept their own, which had been in place for, I don't know how many years. Do you know how many years? I don't.

[04:52:16] No, but it's been a long time with the same basic funding. The education committees in both the House and the Senate passed our SOQs, that is the board's SOQs, unanimous, well, not unanimously the first year, but we got to unanimity. Pretty close. but the budget committee killed us and it wasn't frankly on policy either because they did increase the amount of money it was nobody wanted to tinker with the budget once it got that far I mean that's the political reality of it whether you like to say it that way or not but that's what happened I guess Mr. President what I was getting at is that these highlighted amounts who put those

[04:52:54] highlighted in a moment. Sure. And I can, for that, all the highlighted areas, whether it is data points or it is dollar amounts, those are in the process of being updated. For those in particular related to the SOQ prescriptions, those are put together by our Department of Budget or Office of Budget. And so they run the cost calculations against the current funding model to get us what it would cost to prescribe or to fund those standards of quality recommendations or prescriptions these are from 2021 and they gave you these amounts for each one of these 11. yes ma'am

[04:53:32] that's based on requests from this board yes ma'am i did update one of them um remember which one i believe it was the reading specialist prescription or no sorry excuse me it was the elementary school principals prescription number seven that was fully funded in the 2324 appropriation act so that is accurate but all of the others still need to be updated for the realistic cost to be honest they're probably not too far off since we're only one year removed but

[04:54:07] i didn't want folks to think those were the the true cost right now yeah so the the standards of quality effectively are the minimum staffing required by every division and we've already in this our months had some really rich deep conversations about really complex topics so i actually think the decision of the of the board a number of years ago to say hey based on all these rich conversations lots of complex topics we think if you're going to move the needle you should look at staffing this way and i think that was appropriate and prudent and again the the board we get to say this is what we think the soq should be the general assembly gets to say we agree or we're going to fund it or we're not that that's their their role i don't think although

[04:54:46] we're in the midst of lots of rich discussions i don't think between now and next month we're going to be able to look at that list so again this is not a recommendation it's kind of where i am right now thinking out loud with with my colleagues i'm inclined to you know let that part go that was well reasoned um it's not been funded i think you know if we want to come back and look at that another point in time that that that's uh fine um i some of those things did bear fruit though such as the literacy act bill included reading specialists you know so i think that that kind of recommendation in there is quite quite good so that's the soq piece i'm really kind of interested

[04:55:20] in uh grace's perspective on just other aspects of the report yeah um you know um one thing that i think we cannot highlight too much is the staffing crisis um and what that looks like not just at the teacher shortage level but you know we're also having a problem growing school leaders so um if

[04:55:52] you're a teacher like you're not i mean back in you know the 2005 to 2012-ish range you had a lot of people wanting to move out of the classroom into school leadership and that's just not happening at the rates that we need it to happen um so that that's kind of one of one of the things that that um you know i i really looked at um you know not only that but i think we have to talk about sort of these kind of side burdens that i mentioned um during the previous presentation about so what

[04:56:32] are what's what's preventing our teachers from going into those leadership roles in school divisions things like they're not actually like doing the things that that they want to do which is being the instructional leader of a school really affecting how kids are learning and how teachers are teaching and really working on that particular um that is their focus as a building

[04:57:02] principal in the world of everything is perfect. I will say another piece that I really would like for this board to encourage as far as funding mechanisms go, and this is something that I don't think I've discussed with this board before, but it's something that absolutely gets on my very Lassner, and that is when I was a teacher, the state would send us, let's say, a 5% teacher salary increase, and you'd hear it from the General Assembly.

[04:57:38] You're going to get a 5% increase if you're a teacher and your salary. Well, the practical, how that practically plays out in the pocket of a teacher is that that teacher actually may only see about 2.5% of that 5% increase because the locality takes that other 2.5% to basically subsidize the increase in the VRS amount that it costs the locality to take on that increase in teacher salary. So I would really like for us to address

[04:58:15] that, particularly that issue, because I think that that is not only going to help us in recruitment, but it's also going to help us in retention. Another piece that I would really love to see is some increased professionalism that we pass on to our early childhood educators.

[04:58:44] This is something that I've talked to Jenna about previously and to the early childhood team, but I would really like for us not just to focus on increasing what an early childhood educator takes home in their pocket, but also increasing their sense of professionalism in their craft to set up a system of certification for those educators that is just as rigorous as the system that we have in place for our K-12 teachers.

[04:59:18] So those are just some thoughts that I had as I looked at this report. And one data point that I wanted to see some clarification on, if we had it, was the issue of retirements.

[04:59:38] So the data that's reflected in the report, is that a typical retirement data point? Or is that more significant since the pandemic?

[04:59:54] How does it relate to that? I think that's important to informing the discussion as well on the staffing issue. i'm dumping so i i i'll need to check on that miss creasy but i do think that may be a challenge for us to get some trend line data simply because the positions and extra collection survey data that's a that's a new collection and so i just don't know that we would have you know the even the last few years of data to to be able to show trend line but i'll double check and get back to

[05:00:23] deal on that. I know those of you sitting around this table know this too, but I was absolutely like kicked in the gut over the number of critical short or the critical shortage list. I mean, you can absolutely attest to this, Alan, that, you know, you would never have ever before seen

[05:00:56] a critical shortage in history, social science, or English. When I was coming out of my education prep program, you were lucky as a history teacher to get a job because they were so few and far between. It absolutely punched me in the gut. And I think that it only further speaks to just what we're dealing with here. And so I think that that cannot be overstated. I had a question. When you

[05:01:36] say encouraging teachers to get into more, what do you mean by leadership role? Is it like getting away from teaching, active teaching into other administrative? So typically that's how we grow our, and by licensure, in order to qualify for an administrator supervision license, you have to have been under a teacher contract for three years at least so yes we grow teachers by way of our

[05:02:09] our licensure requirements but um we we grow our building administrators that way as well and so we're just not seeing that transition out of the classroom and and and i it's not to encourage those people feel a calling to staying in a classroom their entire career. But some people would love to get into leadership, so principal, central office leadership, but those different

[05:02:44] leadership opportunities in a school division are becoming less of what we as teachers in the classroom would expect those positions to be it's much more um those are much more positions of that are hindered by data collection and less um less of the getting into a classroom and actually impacting student outcomes as a building leader is that clear yeah i'm just just curious because

[05:03:23] i think i had mentioned this at the last meeting that i saw this chart and i was stunned that this this is from the national center for education statistics that from 2000 to 2019 there was a 88 increase in the administrative um staff principals uh no administrative staff and for principals and assistant the 37 increase but the teachers actually doing the instruction and the teaching just kind of kept pace with the about eight percent get pace with the students

[05:03:59] increase so i mean i i'd say that there's more of a need for basic teacher and that could be reflected in the number of positions that became available versus those that were vacant or um so do i think that that number could be a bit skewed or not exactly what we're looking at so it's harder to get principals now it may be that there were more positions available and so that's why that number

[05:04:34] was bigger that 88 percent do you follow me i think mrs chrissy you could also say that that number may also be larger because you have more administrators that are doing things that don't necessarily relate to the job so you kind of you know whether it's student discipline issues um you know classroom management challenges so you know you're often having more administrators but they can't necessarily focus on the job that they need to would this report annual report also have is this also like a this so you're saying this is also like a wish list in addition to it does not

[05:05:10] have to be is what i'm saying it has been in the past but it is not part of the requirement that it be a wish list unless that wish list is sort of what we as a group believe some of the solutions are i mean but it's more than just the like the data the actual assessment data historically been more than the data because we believe that it is a document that communicates with the general assembly in particular uh you can think of it in part as a lobbying document right for education because that's our role is to promote that i'm not saying lobbying for what exactly yet but we are

[05:05:47] you know legislators will look to the document and you know one of the points that has come up in conversation not just with jillian this year but in prior years you know by me talking to the board is when the reports say everything's okay it's difficult to go to the assembly and say we either need more money or you need to change the way you're spending the money you're spending and it's you know the tone of the report in let's say 10 years ago was we're the best in the nation you know essentially uh correct me on this emily but you know what i'm talking about i never

[05:06:24] actually said the best but we highlighted the positives if i were writing this report alone honestly i would start with what are likely to be the nape scores and you know because it is a report on the conditions and needs and say you know we got options how are we going to attract and retain teachers? How are we going to better mentor building leaders, you know, principals, et cetera? I would build a report in this particular case from what I believe will be the stark reality of Monday's data dump, you know, into something that said, here's where we're going.

[05:07:01] And, you know, candidly, we talked about accreditation today. It may not be the report contains a recommendation, but signaling in advance that there may be a desire to decouple accreditation and accountability may not be harmful to the board in turn you know so nobody is surprised if we move into you know january and you know somebody in the legislature picks up it would allow them i mean again assuming it's something we want to do this is not like i'm drafting it it's just if i were drafting it these are the kinds of things i would want to see in it

[05:07:35] because it then sets the stage for actions that we would have later and it allows members of the assembly in particular and of course the executive branch but most of what we're going to need done is going to come out of the legislature right whether it comes through the governor's budget or it comes elsewhere it's going to be a legislative action i think we need to be uh signaling at least directionally if not providing express solutions mr president you just basically stole my cue card so thank you i appreciate your leaving no you did it very well but i

[05:08:10] just will echo it i their outline i think is terrific but i i do think that you know we are in a once in a lifetime or generational challenge coming out of covet and i think that we should be leading with you know addressing the massive challenges both to the students and um and you know the title one here is learning loss but it's broader than that i think it's the overall you know quality and you know capacity and other um issues and i i think there's a second issue there too that's missing and I do think it's the parental involvement which is also I think been changed

[05:08:49] forever these last couple years with you know the insights that the parents have been able to understand and to have them involved in the process and I think to your point then One, it becomes the issue of funding, the issue of the teacher, both quality as well as the capacity and what we need, and then also the other tools that we need to address these, whether it's, again, our standards, our assessment systems, our, you know, the lab schools and some of the practical things that would, you know, again, dovetail into

[05:09:28] the legislative process. And so, again, I think the content that's in here is terrific, but I think it really is, you know, addressing the different focus. Yeah. And if I may just add, as a layperson, which I am, you know, layperson looking at what the board is.

[05:09:46] I'm on the board, but I'm a layperson looking at the, you know, they're just thinking about, is my child getting a good education? And what is my child experiencing in the school? Why is my child getting a survey? Or why is my child being data mined?

[05:10:02] or things like that i think some of my asks just as a regular person a parent on the ground i i do appreciate what you just added uh now but would be that um what is the long-term goal for some of these surveys um you know and i get i get emails every day from parents who were talking about their concerns and a lot of these surveys so if i were to build a wish list

[05:10:33] my wish list would be innovation um get make all of these surveys opt in not opt out uh in in fact make a lot of things that the schools um that are not mandated mandatory opt in rather than opt out um and you know more towards educational freedom for parents and families so i i would definitely have this is about the child it's not about a system it's about every child so what happens

[05:11:10] i'll be pretty brief i agree with with much what's been said um i do think on this on the sort of wish list i do think we should think about think strategically i've always wondered with that it's so many things how do you actually decide we should be thinking in terms of like priorities and you know rather than like here's a grab bag we'd be happy with any of that we probably want to be a little strategic i've just always wondered if that works against the board because it's sort of it's like a shotgun approach rather than you know uh being real focused i just think that's something for us to think about um i mean emily writing a report by committee is like you know obviously one of those fun things anyone can ever get to do um uh i actually think there's a lot of good

[05:11:50] content here i i have an organizational it kind of goes to where you are going mr president like i think we should have like long-standing issues and so forth should be one section probably lower down and then we should start with the pandemic because i do think there's there's some sort of more acute immediate issues i think that's in here it just sort of it's a very long narrative so this is like a structural kind of suggestion and then i do think yeah we should forecast and this is a discussion we should have with with more board members that are here like you know we've obviously got accountability accreditations come

up we're doing lab schools um uh we should probably just talk about the standards reviews are going to happen there seems

[05:12:27] to be you know confusion about timelines and so forth and just talk about what's coming up or what people should expect um assessments things like that i think like a section sort of forecasting that there's a lot and that gives it kind of a flow like these immediate challenge and mr hansen spoke to that too the longer standing things and then kind of what what what to expect um and then if we decide if the board decides it wants to have a list that's a good place to put it um uh as well so that's you know uh i think there's there's work to do but like i think you can sort of see the you you can certainly see your way with what we have to where we need to get

[05:13:03] and do you have maybe to step one other thing i i think um secretary gadara too does a very nice job of talking about whether cte and maybe i missed this when i stepped out i don't know grace and brought this up or something but i think that you know preparing students not just for you know traditional post-secondary education but for the workforce and i think with a lot of the things that the governor is trying to bring into the state with you know the lego or the other type of opportunities i just think you know trying to also articulate you know what the student experience

[05:13:42] needs to be to prepare them for the multitude of pathways that are out there for them um i think should be woven into this as well you know i agree with that i will make one comment on that and not only to not complicate it this year because we have the profile of virginia graduate which lays out the current pathways right because of the fact that we're going to have divergent

[05:14:16] viewpoints on the board it might be best this year to limit ourselves to conditions and needs as the report is required i don't know that but i'm just offering that as a potential way to get through this in 30 days if i had 60 honestly i would start to incorporate more bill i am concerned about uh redrafting and coming back to the board and having to do a major rewrite and still get it done i mean i am concerned about that which doesn't mean i don't want to incorporate those things it just i'm looking at the practicality of it can we include like descriptive data like again like the

[05:14:56] act benchmarks i think are sort of useful you know i feel like there's probably stuff you know you know obviously some college board does probably like maybe a bunch of descriptive data we can put in there to kind of get at this without getting into your concern that it becomes you know an unmanageable and it may not become unmanageable but i know i look at emily sitting there and thinking how am i going to get from here to there in a manner that makes sense because what's going going to happen is there'll be a rewrite put out, right? Everybody will get a shot at that. Emily

[05:15:30] will get, you know, seven to eight to ten comments from everybody. There's no way to resolve the comments because none of us have more weight than the other ones on the board, right? I mean, you know, correcting the typos is one thing, but the substantive comments, it's not like everybody gets what they want in. It's the board gets as a whole to decide what goes in. And so it's a difficult task. I mean, I've seen this, you know, every year. Six years. Yeah, every year now.

[05:15:58] And so I'm just trying to streamline that. But if there's pushback on that streamlining, I am happy to accept that pushback. And Mr. President, I would also offer, you know, I'm happy to, I know we've been a little bit pressed for time today. I'm happy to have this discussion again tomorrow.

[05:16:15] You know, I know we've been talking a little bit more holistically or kind of visionary about where the report should go. You know, if you'd like me to kind of help facilitate a discussion on like each section or some other things you know maybe even take tonight to talk about it as well um you know i i certainly want your feedback and want to get this right um and so happy to to continue the conversation tomorrow we agreed that there ought to be sort of a priority shifting a thematic shift

[05:16:46] to geez we got a problem first to i mean is that yeah again i'm not looking to dictate this i just Because that, I think, will help Emily when it comes time to reorganizing the basic pattern.

[05:17:02] If we believe, as a group, we're going to start there first. Watch the videotape of what it said. Absolutely. No, you know what I mean. But I think that's the headline of the year for the board, right? I mean, we've got to say we've got a problem. Absolutely. And I think, you know, if I were to just off the top of my head reorganize this now, certainly I'd start with the NAEP scores that are going to be coming out on Monday and then follow that up with the staffing challenges.

[05:17:26] I think those are probably the two kind of biggest things that I'm hearing from you all today. Obviously, again, we can continue those conversations, but those are some pretty big challenges that, you know, geez, we have a problem. I would probably take out some of the self-congratulatory stuff.

[05:17:44] You know, honestly, nobody wants to look to us as models of civic anything right now. So, you know what I mean? I think we can tighten it up quite a bit. Mr. President, I really appreciate how humble you always are with respect to the authority and persuasion that this board has.

[05:18:06] But I would encourage this board to really lend its persuasion to the entire Commonwealth to say we recognize that there's an issue. We recognize the urgency. And this is a message to all of Virginia. Yeah, I think that, and that's what I am exactly saying, the paragraph I want to pull is the one that talks about, you know, let's say in the model for civic righteousness or something in there.

[05:18:31] I don't think we use civic righteousness. There's something in there. I'll show you the one that I want out. Mr. President, just a comment here. I mean, I kind of see this almost as sort of a legislative agenda in some way, shape, or form. And so what I would like, I mean, I think it's probably easier to outline problem, solution, problem, solution, because or or, you know, or even problem.

[05:19:00] We're going to work on a solution. Right. And and and how can we get to that solution? Or we feel that this the solution comes in this way, shape or form, whatever it may be. But perhaps that's a means by which to get to where we want to go with this.

[05:19:17] i do think that there is an introduction of sorts that says that does give um praise to the work of the board and what it has done um and and you know somewhat thanking um you know the governor of the general assembly for recognizing the need um and supporting those needs that we have addressed before now whatever anyway you know where i'm going it's a late hour at this point yeah and so i was doing on it it's like on the statistics i do think we really need to make sure

[05:19:55] we're showing they like what are like the comment earlier was really important that like we're seeing shortages in areas we haven't seen shortages before like some of this can bring to people like we always say this and some of these are long-standing problems that we should talk about they're not new pandemic problems they're just problems people are paying attention to during the pandemic but just with these statistics really show like what are changes in base rates like i was struck number of teachers leaving mid-year jumped pretty substantially and that's like something to pay that's like something to pay

attention to that's not just like hyperbole or or you know um whatever and so just to make sure we're sort of presenting things that people can see what is it what is like a real change that you should pay attention to and what is

[05:20:35] like a longer term trend that we're just now looking at from a employment perspective over overall you the the previous benefits of being an educator are just not what people care about anymore right like that that's just a fact and so i think that also informs the workforce discussion emily do you have enough to start i think we'll need a little bit more discussion tomorrow but i

[05:21:10] can think about that tonight we do let me ask if it would be all right with the board if we could allow emily and i to at least turn something around i mean and you know work together i i think i've got a sense directionally but you know if anybody else wants to step up and take that role i would be delighted also i think that makes sense i think you've got the gist of it and

[05:21:43] and under the laws you can send us a draft and we can yes one-on-one yeah as long as we don't do reply alls we can respond one-on-one absolutely you may send emily all the suggestions you like because she'll do the original drafting i'll just get to uh tinker with placements is that acceptable i mean again not looking to impose anything on the board just one thing that i'd also

[05:22:19] ask um miss rotham to your point if if there are specific data pieces i mean obviously i've weaved some in um have gotten a sense of some of what you'd like but if there are other data pieces that you want please let me know i can see what we have here internally or if we need to even look at national data you know sometimes with our research office it can take a little bit of time to get that so if you have data pieces you'd like that those are some key pieces i'd like to know sooner than later yeah i will say if we get a draft turned around in basically 10 12 days comments

[05:22:53] coming back you guys have to commit to being fairly prompt with comments coming back thank you we will note that on the record grace on your permanent record well that might fall and help me to do something yes pam did you have a comment no okay all right so we all know where we're going thank you very much thanks emily and uh i guess dinner at 6 15. i did yeah followed by uh nine

[05:23:32] o'clock tomorrow morning here packed day thank you all very much for the time and attention